

BLOOD RELATIVES

An Inspector Griffin Mystery

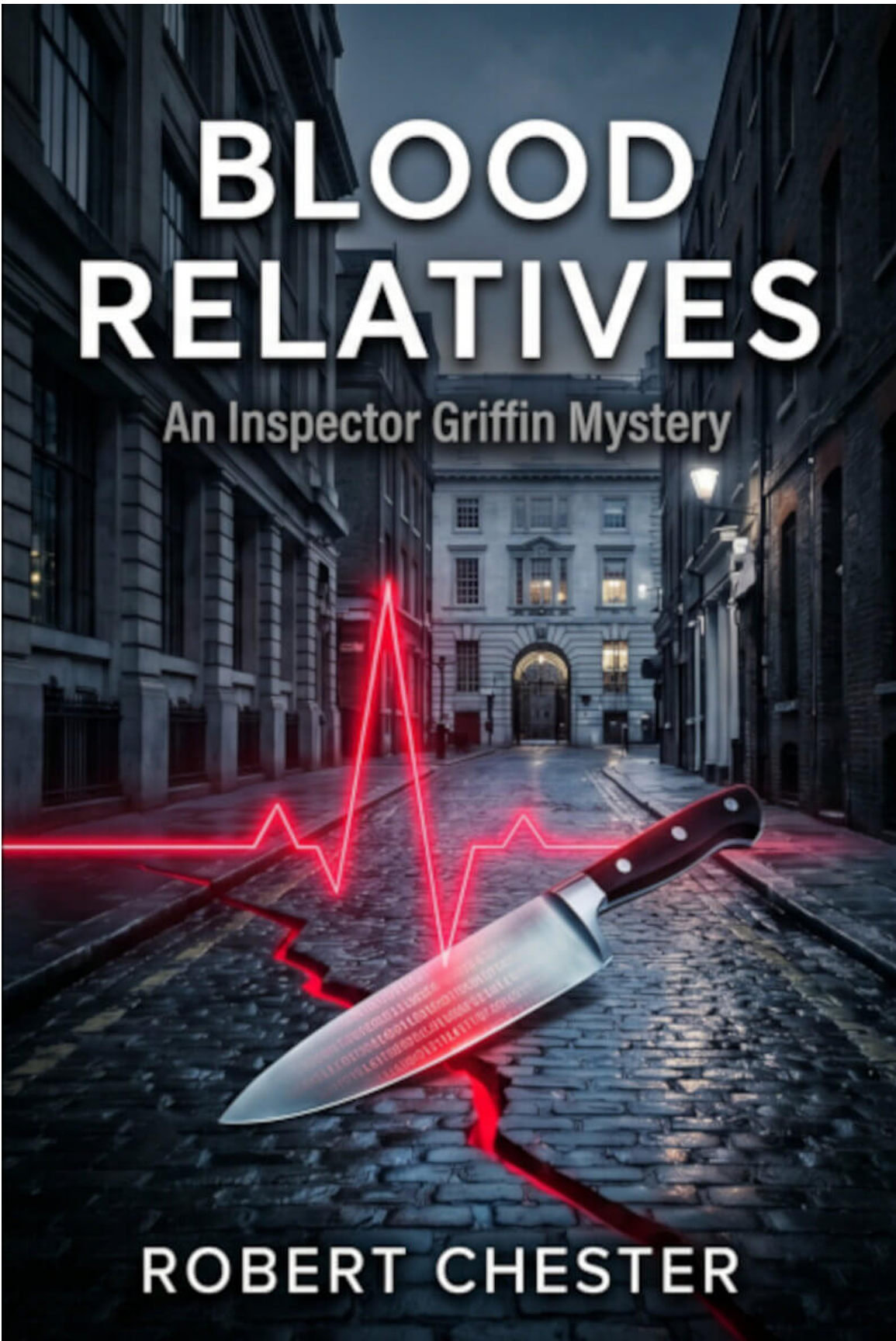


ROBERT CHESTER

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Dedication

*To Andy, with love.
You are more than everything to me.*

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Blood Relatives

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Chapter One

Waterloo Station in London is a major train terminus handling nearly 60 million passengers a year.. Adam Griffin was convinced they were all there today and all of them had been told to get in his way. He wasn't rushing but it was still frustrating.

As he left the station he was relieved to see there were a lot fewer people. At last, some breathing space. He started to set some music on his phone for the twenty minute walk home and put his ear buds in. The music was too loud so he looked down to adjust the volume.

In his peripheral vision he caught a flash of white and looked up sharply as a white van mounted the kerb just a few feet away. The road is supposed to be used for cabs and deliveries so normally the traffic is slow moving but this van was moving fast, and accelerating.

Almost transfixed, Adam started to move back when he felt a huge tug on his backpack, slamming him backwards until he fell in a tangled mess on top of his rescuer. The last thing Adam saw before he hit the ground was his phone flying into the air.

Oh shit, he thought, please don't break.

From the corner of his eye, a hand flew up and snatched the phone from the air, holding it aloft like Excalibur rising from the lake. Safe.

Suddenly there were lots of passers-by offering help and opinions – mostly opinions.

“It was a kid in a hoodie,” someone said

“wearing a surgical mask,” another voice joined in.

“I thought it was a girl driving,” a third voice.

“probably on the bloody phone.” Everyone had an opinion.

Adam wasn't the centre of attention though. Another man had been about to rack up a Santander public bike across the road after he'd hired it. The van had caught the back wheel of the bike and essentially destroyed it. Snatched it from his hands. There was much discussion about whether he'd be liable and whether it was still on hire to him.

A woman who was about to step off the pavement and jog to work had been clipped on the arm by the door mirror. She was assuring everyone that she was a nurse working locally in Accident and Emergency and would get it checked at work.

Mostly people just kept walking past. Some people tutted as they had to step around the two bodies on the ground.

Adam took a deep breath and caught a scent in the air. Close by.

Chanel Pour Monsieur, he thought to himself. *Classic fragrance. Stylish.*

He rolled over, off the other body, and came up on to his hands and knees.

“Thank you,” he said to his saviour, “that was stupidly close.”

Coming up into a sitting position Finn Williams grinned back at him. “I thought that van driver had it in for you. I hope he had as much of a scare as me.”

“I know! I think I’m jinxed. I fell under a tube train last month. Now this.”

Adam tilted his head to one side and looked again. “I know you. We were at school together.”

“You’re right, but maybe we should get out of the way of all these people.”

The both stood, pulling each other up and moved towards the building to recover.

“Finn, Finn Williams,” said Finn, holding out his hand.

“Adam Griffin – we were in the same year but... didn’t you disappear from school mysteriously.”

“Long story but yes, it was just after you and I had a bit of a moment at a party.” Finn wiggled his eyebrows and smiled.

“I remember it well,” Adam laughed. “A pile of coats in a darkened bedroom I think.”

“It was the week after my sixteenth birthday but someone else was having a house party. I seem to remember you said what we did was your favourite number.”

“It still is.” Adam beamed.

He gave Finn the once over, fairly subtly. Finn was about the same height as him, around 6 foot and looked to be in good shape. In very good shape in fact. They were both twenty one, both with dark hair but Adam had soft brown eyes compared to Finn’s blue eyes.

Both liked what they saw.

“Listen, I’d really like to go for a coffee if you’re free.” said Adam.

Finn hesitated and grimaced “I’ve got a circuit training class I really shouldn’t miss.”

Adam spoke before he thought “Do you always wear Chanel cologne to the gym?” he smiled.

“What? Oh... well spotted... or sniffed maybe.”

“I’m sorry,” said Adam sheepishly. “I have this weird sense of smell. My Grandmother used to say I had a nose like a dog, which now I think about doesn’t sound like a compliment.”

They smiled at each other, both a little unsure.

“Don’t worry” Finn replied “At worst you could get a job at an airport. It’s a classic though and I used to steal it from my dad but now it’s my daily choice”

“I remember” said Adam “it’s my second best memory of that party”.

Adam blushed a little, which Finn thought was attractive.

“But... if you’re free tomorrow...”

“Deal!” said Adam. “I’m free all day tomorrow. No lectures. No commitments”

“How about 2pm ish”

“I know a fantastic little place that would be ideal. It’s like a greasy spoon cafe but with the best coffee you’ve ever tasted.”

“OK, let’s swap numbers and you can message me the details”

They swapped phones and each entered their contact details. As he gave it back Adam held the phone for a second longer.

“Tomorrow you can tell me the long story of your mysterious disappearance. I missed you”

The boys locked eyes. They exchanged an unspoken agreement.

As they walked off in opposite directions they both had a small smile playing across their lips.

Finn got home from circuit training feeling tired but energised. He loved the communal feel of the class. A little competition from others and a little banter. He liked that each person could work to their limit without any pressure. As they went round the stations in the room each person worked on their own but with the comfort of seeing others suffering. It made him smile.

As he let himself in, his dad was sitting at the dining table looking at his laptop. He kissed his dad on the top of his head and felt an arm slide round his waist.

Marc Williams was in his late 40's and his once brown hair had gone steel grey, if you were optimistic but closer to white in reality. Finn hoped he had inherited those genes because he thought his dad looked pretty good. He was fit and in good shape – the whole family would run frequent half-marathons and regularly took part in park-runs.

“Did you have a good day?” he asked his dad.

“Not bad. No bad guys locked up but some progress made”

Detective Inspector Marcus Williams ran a unit for the Metropolitan Police investigating cyber crime and he loved his job.

“How about you?” he asked his son.

“Oh you know. Normal stuff. Rescued a cute guy from the path of a speeding van. He fell on top of me. There was a bit of a spark. Went to circuit training”. Finn couldn't keep a straight face as he finished.

“A spark is it?” Finn had no reason to hide anything from his dad.

“Well I hope this boy's intentions are honourable or I'll need my shotgun”

“We'll see...” said Finn as he pulled away from his dad “I could do with some dishonourable intentions to be honest”

Walking upstairs to his room, Finn started to pull off his sweaty shirt. As he shut the door he stripped off completely and looked at himself

in the full length mirror.

Not bad he thought. Good muscle definition, nice arms and a slightly defined six pack that didn't look AI enhanced. He thought about Adam with his cropped short dark hair and his eyes like velvety chocolate. He wondered what Adam would look like naked. Certainly different to when they had their last encounter. He'd filled out, looked more muscular. He looked like he took care of himself. He looked...

Oh-oh thought Finn *I need to stop thinking about Adam or I'll need to take care of myself too*. He crossed the hallway into the bathroom. He didn't need to cover up because only his dad was home and anyway... nobody would mind.

As the shower warmed up Finn reflected on life in general. He knew he was lucky to be living in a stable home, in a really great location. He could walk to the gym near Waterloo Station in ten minutes. He could also walk to the Tate Modern art gallery, the theatres on the South Bank, Borough Market and just a bit further across the river was Soho, Covent Garden and all the attractions London had to offer.

He was benefiting from a police officer and a paramedic living together and qualifying as essential workers twice over. Originally they had rented their house, when the area was deeply unfashionable. Ultra-convenient but anywhere south of the river was considered undesirable.

Finn remembered, as a kid, the street had a lot of trouble and some unpleasant residents. There were several kids Finn was instructed to stay away from. Now, there was a TV director living next door. Three doors down was a Member of Parliament and there were at least three well known actors.

He was towelling himself off when he recalled Adam's parting comment about his mysterious disappearance.

Should I tell all? thought Finn *I don't want to scare him off*. On the other hand, he wanted to be honest.

It had been a week and one day after that party, two weeks after his sixteenth birthday, when there had been a ferocious banging on his front door at 6am. Finn and his dad were alone in the house because paramedic shifts included nights.

Four large men in suits identified themselves to Marc and came in. Marc told them he was a police officer but they already knew that. After a brief conversation with his dad the pair of them were put in the back of a black Range Rover and driven off. The other two stayed at the house.

As the car crossed Westminster Bridge, it turned left just after Big Ben. Marc knew where they were heading and, unknown to him at the time, so did Finn.

They drove along Millbank and turned twice into a parallel road behind an impressive looking office block. They pulled up next to a single door with a small simple sign alongside saying Thames House.

Marc and Finn both knew where they were. They were at MI5, the home of British domestic intelligence.

They were led inside and the two burly men were replaced by a lovely looking young woman in her late 20's who led them to a meeting room. Marc was relieved it didn't look like an interrogation room but said nothing.

Within one minute a tall, slim man appeared through the door. He was well dressed, but dishevelled, like he'd been up all night. He was in his early 50's and didn't look friendly.

"Finn Williams..." he consulted the file in front of him. "We have evidence that you have gained unauthorised access to computers systems contrary to the Computer Misuse Act 1990 and by the unauthorised modification of computer material, under section three of that law you may be liable for an unlimited fine and up to ten years imprisonment"

Marc was shocked but kept a calm poker face. He'd been involved in many interviews like this and was also aware that Finn was a computing genius.

"What is this evidence against my son?" he asked.

"Well for starters, we have a text file containing the words 'Finn was here'"

Marc suppressed a nervous smile "and what computer systems are we talking about?"

"Well, MI5 obviously" the man said, gesturing around. "And we are investigating further breeches. Further charges could follow you know"

"What other systems..." Marc started

"We can hold you for up to 14 days without charge under the Terrorism Act you know"

"I am well aware of the law, thanks"

"MI6..." Finn said confidently. Both men turned to look at him. "And the government communications centre at GCHQ. Border Force, the Foreign Office, more or less all the major utility companies, all the big banks and 27 giant corporations. Check it out... 'Finn was here' is all over the place."

"This is a very serious matter young man..." the unidentified man started to say as the door opened.

"Thank you Robert, I'll take over now" A newcomer entered the room carrying in a single, thin, file. He was polished and immaculately dressed. Very shiny shoes that Marc recognised as hand-made.

He sat, exuding the sort of confidence that came with a very expensive education and a rarefied, cultured existence. This was a chief, not an indian.

He didn't introduce himself. He was the sort of man who you just knew was important.

"Well Finn" he smiled at Finn "I have three choices open to me. Perhaps you, and your father, can help me make the right decision"

Marc narrowed his eyes. He felt this man had already made his mind up but he had no choice but to let him play out his game.

"I could have you prosecuted, as my colleague said, under the Computer Misuse Act with a maximum sentence of 10 years."

He held out one hand as if weighing that option, then extending another hand to balance.

"Or... I could have you both taken to the basement and shot in the head"

He gave a thin smile, clearly enjoying the theatricality of his little show

"Or...?" said Marc.

"Maybe there is no other option" the polished gentleman replied

Marc took a deep breath to reply but Finn spoke. Quietly but with confidence.

"Computers are pure logic" he said "If you do x and y the answer is always z" If the answer doesn't compute, it means you've made a mistake somewhere."

Finn wasn't feeling at all confident but he knew he couldn't show that. Suddenly, spiders popped into his head. *They're more scared of you than you are of them, he thought.*

He smiled slowly, unnervingly, across the table.

"Option one won't fly because you'd need to admit in open court that a sixteen year old kid accessed one of the most secure systems in the country. If a kid could do it, what could Russia do? Or China?"

The man brushed non-existent fluff from his immaculately pressed trousers.

“Option two *sounds* attractive but it doesn’t answer any of your questions. The how, when and why. And... compellingly, what else”

Finn smiled and, surprisingly, the man smiled back.

“So, logic dictates that your file contains a copy of the Official Secrets Act for me to sign and a job offer”

The man looked at Marc across the table “Don’t you just hate young people?” and he pushed the file across the table.

And that’s how it started. A 16 year old schoolboy recruited by the intelligence services as a good way of shutting him up and tapping into his astonishing grasp of cyber security.

Chapter Two

Finn followed the pin that Adam had dropped but it didn't seem to make sense. He peered down a narrow alley tucked behind the Theatre Royal Drury Lane in London's theatre district. It wasn't wide enough for a car and seemed unlikely to house a coffee shop or a cafe.

He was about to message Adam when he felt a tap on his shoulder.

"You found it then" said Adam brightly

"Well, I think I'm in the right area but..."

"Trust me, you'll love it" Adam grabbed Finn's arm and guided him down the alley. To Finn's amazement the alley widened out slightly and, to one side and totally hidden from the road, was a double fronted shop with a central door and frosted glass up to head height. There was absolutely no signage or display outside except for a sign in the door that had been turned to say "Open".

Adam held the door open and Finn went in first. There was a man behind the counter at the back who looked at Finn like he'd dragged in a bag of dead rats.

There were about 16 tables, some for two people, some for four. About half were occupied.

Pulling Finn over to the counter, Adam spoke to the man. "Tony, this is my friend Finn" there was a slight pause before he added "is he OK?"

"I don't know. Do you think he's OK?"

"I think he's more than OK Tony"

The man nudged his head to one side in a gesture of acceptance.

"OK, then I guess he's OK"

Adam took them both to a table for two in the corner and made Finn sit looking out to the cafe. Finn was slightly confused because he felt like he's just been vetted for membership of a posh golf club.

As soon as they sat a waitress came over. Her name badge said 'Nikki'. She was about thirty five and looked tired already, as if she'd been on her feet since dawn. She changed the small pot of plastic flowers on the table.

"All our flowers get rinsed under the tap regularly – that's why they don't die" she said.

Finn thought she was joking but in a dry deadpan way, but that made it difficult to tell.

They ordered two flat white coffees and decided to wait before ordering food. The waitress had brightened up taking their order and seemed almost friendly – at least she was to Adam.

"This is my favourite cafe." Adam told Finn. "I virtually live here. It's intriguing and full of dark history" He leant forward to whisper. "The waitress fascinates me. She always makes sure she serves me, I think she has a crush but hasn't realised she's barking up the wrong tree. Usually she's a bit more flirty but I think you've scared her"

"Isn't she a bit old for you?" Finn watched the waitress across the room "Actually she's quite good looking but just looks totally knackered"

"Also..." said Adam with a chuckle "she always wears those latex gloves. But here's the weird thing, she has a faint smell of alcohol based hand sanitiser about her but I've never seen any in the cafe"

"Is that your strange sense of smell again? And you think *she's* weird?"

Adam laughed. "Let me tell you about this place. It's not like a private club or anything but you wouldn't know it was here unless a regular introduced you. If Tony doesn't like you, he'll make it clear and you probably won't come back."

The waitress brought their coffees. Finn noticed that there was a small biscuit on the saucer of Adam's coffee but not on his.

When she'd gone Adam continued "Tony is known to everyone as Maltese Tony, but don't ever call him that to his face"

"Is he from Malta?" asked Finn.

"No, his granddad was from Italy and arrived here in 1939 just as the war started. Because Italians were being rounded up and interned, he claimed to be from Malta and got some dodgy paperwork to prove it. Apparently he was a petty thief in Italy and arrived here with a wad of cash, probably stolen. It was enough to buy this place for a song"

Adam looked around to make sure nobody else was listening.

"Now, getting Maltese papers meant he came into contact with a Maltese gangland family called the Messina Brothers because they ran most of the prostitution in London from the 1930's. Grandad – aka Maltese Frank - didn't mind because he was used to shady contacts so he arranged for the Maltese gentlemen to run a brothel upstairs."

"It's not a brothel nowadays. Tony has converted it to a fantastic apartment and lives with his wife and daughter"

Adam caught the eye of their waitress and she headed over, ignoring another customer.

"Are you hungry?" he asked Finn. "If you eat meat they do a bacon sandwich that will make you faint. All organic bacon on hand baked ciabatta bread"

"It is good" said the waitress "and probably the most expensive bacon sandwich in the world" she snorted slightly.

Once they had ordered Adam continued his story.

"When the Maltese mob started to lose control of Soho and the prostitution game, Tony's dad wanted to pull out of the original deal.

By all accounts Eddie...”

“Maltese Eddie?” Finn interjected.

“Indeed, he was as tough as old boots and mean too. There was a bit of a hoo-ha with gangs wanting to take over the brothel or deal drugs from the cafe but Eddie was having none of it.”

“Hoo-ha sounds like an understatement” said Finn.

“Yeah, it was a bit nasty by all accounts. But Eddie retired to Italy before Brexit and Tony runs this gourmet caff like it was a secret club” Adam said ‘caff’ the way a true Londoner would and grinned broadly at Finn.

“It’s certainly a mix of interesting people” he told Adam.

“Don’t get me started on the customers!!” whispered Adam. “The guy in the corner with the suspiciously young lad was in the running for James Bond before Daniel Craig got it. He’s ‘happily married’ according to the media and his publicist but he’s with his ‘twink of the month’. He’ll get bored soon and find another young ‘assistant’. The guy on the next table is a BBC war correspondent. I think he’s seen a few nasty things”

Adam glanced over his shoulder as the door opened “the guy just arriving is called Billy Fish. He’s like a low level fence for stolen goods and sundry items. If you want a set of cast iron cookware, Billy can get them. If you want a container full of TV’s, he’ll sort it. Not sure he’d cope with the Louvre museum robbery or Brinks Mat but... he’d probably know someone.”

Their food arrived so they took a moment to savour the perfectly cooked sandwich.

“So tell me...” Adam said “what was the story of your sudden disappearance”

Finn outlined his story but left out references to the intelligence agencies. He just went with a ‘government department’ but at one

point he mentioned sharing an office overlooking the river on Millbank.

“Thames House?” asked Adam

Finn gave a brief nod. “Not many people would make that connection” he said.

“Well... let’s just say I’ve read a great many crime thrillers. I’ll tell you later” he smiled at Finn with a genuine twinkle in his eye.

“Are you still there?” he asked.

“No I left a year ago and I am part of a white hat hacking collective”

“I understand all those words but have no idea what they mean together” Adam knitted his brow, which Finn thought looked cute.

“There are four of us around the world with some skills that we use to test the integrity of systems for companies and governments. We help them protect themselves against ransomware attacks and malicious hacking.”

“Impressive” said Adam

“and the other thing is a bit like being in the Army Reserves. I could be called upon to help out if there’s a crisis, so you never really leave.”

“Wow, I feel so inadequate. I can barely turn on my laptop. Do you still live at home?”

“Yep, still in the cheapest digs in London. I’ve got a fairly unusual family because my Mum lives in Hampstead and I’ve got a step-mum and a step-dad”

“That doesn’t sound unusual nowadays. Lots of people divorce and re-marry”

“Well...” Finn paused “my Mum and dad were never married, and my dad is married to my step-dad and my Mum lives with my step-mum

Adam raised his eyebrows but said nothing.

“They both wanted children quite young so they had an agreement. My Mum had two kids, about two years apart. A boy for my dad and a girl for her, by sheer coincidence. Later they both met partners and it has been incredibly happy”

“That’s a great story and especially the happy ending”

“How about you” asked Finn “are your parents together”

“Oh good God no. I was mainly brought up by my grandmother who I adored and vice-versa. My dad was over fifty when I was born and a raving alcoholic. I think it was his ambition to drink himself to death but he accidentally drank so much he fell downstairs and broke his neck. I was fourteen and my mother, who has her own issues, decided to take off to Spain. It turned out she’d had ‘a friend’ for several years and he had a villa in some sunny British ghetto in Spain so off they went”

“But your grandma stepped in?” Finn asked.

“Not really stepped in. She’s always been part of my life. She was... indomitable? Resolute? Invincible?” Adam laughed “Actually I think those are three battleships but she was an amazing woman. She was also famous.”

“Really?” smiled Finn “how come?”

“She was Elspeth Potter. The author?”

“Oh my God, she *is* famous. The Inspector Griffin Mysteries”

Elspeth Potter was born in Devon in 1921 and when she was seventeen the estate next door was sold to Agatha Christie and her husband. They became friends despite a thirty year age gap and remained close until Christie's death in 1976. They met regularly and it was Agatha who encouraged Elspeth to write.

When Elspeth produced her first novel in 1942 Agatha declared it a masterpiece and helped her get it published. The very first of sixty five novels, many featuring Inspector Griffin. There were also adapted plays, more than 40 films and a whole host of TV series. One of her books had been remade on screen eight times since the 1940's.

Agatha and Elspeth were both quick-witted and funny, they both hated crowds but they shared a love of mystery, thrills and murder. They would often exchange letters outlining ways to use undetectable poisons or how a murderer could escape leaving a body in a locked room.

When Agatha died Elspeth felt like she'd lost her friend, her mentor and her soulmate. She missed the witty conversations when they met and the beautifully crafted letters they exchanged.

It would be thirty years before she met her next soulmate. The moment she saw her new grandson she was smitten. She became his friend, despite an 84 year age gap. She protected him – including from his own parents, who she considered beyond redemption. Nothing escaped her attention. She knew her son had become an alcoholic and was fiercely resisting any help. She knew Adam's mother had multiple affairs and, in some ways, she couldn't blame her.

Elspeth's husband had died in the 1950's, shortly after their son was born. There was no proof, no compensation or counselling, but Elspeth truly believed he died as a direct response to his wartime experiences. He had had a much decorated but harrowing war.

Unwittingly perhaps, the biggest contribution to Elspeth's life came from Agatha Christie's exceptional skill in financial planning. She badgered Elspeth, from a very early age, to plan for the future. To plan her tax liabilities with all the thoroughness of a well-constructed murder mystery.

Elspeth learnt of trust funds and offshore assets, investments and asset management. She understood property management, inheritance planning and tax avoidance. Not evasion, because everything she did was scrupulously legal.

Although she had an agent, she was closely involved in book sales, stage adaptations on Broadway and the West End, film rights, radio plays and TV series. She had a huge sense of 'doing the right thing' so, if a school wanted to produce one of her plays, it was free. A giant Hollywood studio? They were going to pay... a lot.

When she died, aged 100, Elspeth Potter was virtually penniless. However, her sole beneficiary inherited trust funds and assets worth in excess of £100 million. Adam Griffin was a very rich young man, but he was also a young man with long training, deeply instilled responsibility and a huge dose of common sense.

"It sounds tragically sad to say she was my best friend but... OK, that is sad" Adam laughed, half to himself. "But the truth is she was more of a parent to me than my real parents, and she taught me how to handle money, how to spot what she called 'fakers' but we'd probably call hangers-on or scammers"

He looked sad and Finn reached across and put his hand on top of Adam's.

Adam smiled "Don't get me wrong, I had a fantastic childhood and even when she died, it wasn't sad. We spent her 100th birthday together. We cooked her favourite food and sat and talked. She told me to find a nice boy eventually..."

"She knew you were gay?" Finn interrupted.

"Oh God yes. She was the first person I told, when I was about 12. You'd think she was in her 20's not her 90's. Totally accepting. She told me she'd known a few 'theatrical types' including Noel Coward. Not fazed at all."

"Wow, and I thought my family were cool" said Finn.

“Anyway, she went to bed that night and I think we both knew she wasn’t going to wake up. I was seventeen and I’d lost *her*, my dad and my Mum, although technically she isn’t dead, but somehow I felt excited. Full of life and that was her gift to me”

“So, is that your full time job now? Managing the estate?”

“Nope, I’m in my last year at LSE studying Economics and Financial Management to make me better at managing the ‘family business’ but I’m also completely involved in it too. Currently I’m negotiating an eight part Netflix series based on “Murders at the Races.”

“I’m in awe,” Finn laughed

“What!! With your job history?”

They spent three hours, two coffees, a bacon sandwich and some fizzy water getting re-acquainted. They smiled and laughed the entire time. There was subtle touching of hands on the table to emphasise a point. Knees touched under the table, moving away at first but then staying in contact.

They both knew what was happening, and they were both happy about it.

As they were leaving Maltese Tony looked up from the counter “Finn...” he nodded in Finn’s direction “See you soon”. He nodded at Adam and then went back to his task.

Outside on the pavement, Adam told Finn he’d passed Maltese Tony’s test. Tony liked him and approved.

“It means you can go there on your own and Tony won’t drop hot coffee in your lap. Or you could take someone else...”

“As if,” Finn interrupted, “this is officially ‘our place’ and I can’t think of anyone I’d rather be there with.”

They hugged, longer than necessary, and agreed to meet for pizza the following evening.

As they left Nikki the waitress went over to clear and clean their table, She moved the pot of plastic flowers to wipe down the table and deftly removed a small recording device from the pot. Unnoticed, she slipped it into her pocket.

Chapter Three

Nikki Bartlett had started university studying for a nursing degree in 2012 when she was eighteen. She was excited to start, with good exam results behind her, she moved into the university halls of residence, where she shared space with 2 other girls and a boy. It was freedom for Nikki, a thrilling time away from home, away from constraints and, she hoped, a new start away from the dullness and rigidity of her old life.

She intended to live life to the full.

It took her less than six months to realise she was not a good match for nursing. She did nothing but complain about all 'the sick people' and what she had anticipated as some sort of sanitised role as a 'healer' actually involved an awful lot of quite menial work.

She enjoyed the studying but just couldn't get it into her head that this might be a necessary step along the road. She saw a bleak future of sick people and emptying catheter bags.

So Nikki started partying... hard.

It was just coming up to the end of her first year when Nikki was clubbing with friends. A lot of booze had been drunk, at a cheap 'students night', when Nikki downed a bottle of beer even though she could barely stand.

The beer had been spiked with a huge dose of GHB and, although friends thought Nikki wasn't the target, she had a massive seizure and died on the nightclub floor before paramedics even arrived.

Nikki's friend, and flatmate, left the nightclub almost as soon as Nikki collapsed. Holly Foreman told friends she had been so horrified and upset she just had to run away.

Several other students suggested she should have stayed and helped her friend but she maintained she was distraught and the

shock made her act irrationally. Holly was a loner and, apart from Nikki, had few friends. After Nikki's death she had even fewer.

If those other students could have seen what really happened they would have seen Holly go straight back to Nikki's room. She stole documents and paperwork, a small amount of cash and Nikki's driving licence. Everything she needed to take over Nikki's life – when the time was right.

The police investigation never established who had spiked the drink. No charges were ever brought. It might have been a prank gone wrong, it might have been a date rape attempt. Only one person knew for sure. The person who spiked Nikki's beer – and she wasn't telling anyone.

By any measure Holly Foreman had had a hard life. She'd never known her father and her mother was bi-polar with a huge leaning towards alcoholism. Reliant completely on benefits Holly's mother would sometimes do early morning office cleaning for cash in hand but that was unreliable – mainly because *she* was unreliable.

Holly had to develop self reliance and independence while at the same time acting as a carer for her mother. It was a hard life for a child, cooking, cleaning, putting her drunken mother to bed and lying to social workers about her mother's contribution and abilities.

The alcohol always made her mother's moods worse, up *and* down. There was no pattern or stability. No logic or reason. Every day Holly would come home from school not knowing if her mother would be hyperactively scrubbing the house from top to bottom or would be talking of suicide and despair.

She didn't know if her mother would be awake for days on end or sleeping constantly for days.

It was no way for a child to thrive but for Holly it was normal. She had no benchmark, no real friends with 'normal' families.

Her mother, whichever end of the mood spectrum she was in, was obsessed with Holly's father. Her problems were all caused by him. Holly knew this wasn't completely true. He might have made the situation worse but her mother's symptoms had existed a long time before her parents met.

But, the long repeated tales of blame and recrimination obviously affected Holly.

According to her mother Holly's father abandoned her while she was pregnant. Left her penniless even though he was, she claimed, very wealthy. Their lives would have been so different if he had stayed and done the right thing. They would have had all the advantages in life. Holly could have had a pony or a private education. They would have lived in a luxurious house, maybe with a swimming pool, instead of their terrible public housing.

All Holly knew though is that there was no money for school trips or sports equipment. No money for the latest trainers or mobile phone. Barely enough money for food in fact. Without free meals at school Holly thought she'd have starved. She knew her mother entertained men during the day, just with her hands and mouth, but that was mainly to get money for alcohol.

Most of all Holly felt alone. Alone. Over-burdened and abandoned.

Holly was just short of her fourteenth birthday when she persuaded her mother to ask her doctor for an anti-depressant called Amitriptyline. She'd looked it up on the Internet at the library, she said, and it fit perfectly with her mother's symptoms. It would make her feel so much better. It was quite a hard drug to get, she said, so maybe try telling the doctor she'd had it before for a short period, ten years ago, and it really helped her get back on track.

Her mother had always declined anti-depressants in that illogical way some people do because she didn't want to 'pollute her body'.

This was different though because she knew, even by her low standards, she'd been putting Holly through a really hard time

recently. She tried the doctor and because, like many addicts, she was adept at manipulation she came away with a prescription. When she arrived home Holly was surprised to see a four week supply of the drug.

“I was wrong,” Holly told her mother, “they won’t be good for you because the side effects are really bad. They can cause dizziness and headaches... and you’ll probably put lots of weight on.”

The truth was that her mother was stick-thin because of her drinking and poor nutrition but the very thought of weight gain made her tell Holly to flush the pills down the toilet.

Holly continued her role as carer, nurse and dogsbody while her mother continued to self-medicate with alcohol. Vodka if she could get it or cheap strong lager if she had no money.

She came to resent her mother. She hated the frequently retold stories of what might have been. Her father pin-balled, according to the stories, between a dashing socialite and a park bench alcoholic. He was either witty, urbane and stylish or he was a hopeless drunk with no job and depending totally on handouts from his mother.

Holly wanted to believe the better part but once, in a fit of anger and spite, her mother had told her that she had been conceived in an alley and her father smelt of whisky, vomit and cigarettes. Holly cried that night.

Despite her burdens, Holly did well at school. She wasn’t at all popular and had absolutely no friends but she was diligent and hard working. Her grades were all good, especially in the sciences.

When she was eighteen she was taking her Advanced level exams, hopefully her gateway to university. She had decided to study Nursing because there were grants towards tuition fees and she wouldn’t have a massive debt at the end of it.

On the day of her final exam, Biology, she took her barely awake mother a cup of tea in bed. She noted the empty bottle of vodka that

had been almost full when she helped her mother to bed. The normal routine was that her mother would drink during the night because she woke up and woke up because she drank. It was not unusual.

“Wake up Mum,” she called. “Sit up and drink all your tea, then you can go back to sleep for the day.”

She watched as her mother sipped the tea to test the temperature. She slurped slightly.

I'm surprised she has any taste buds left, Holly thought.

Having supervised the tea drinking, Holly left for school.

It was an uneventful day for Holly. Her exam went as expected and she felt confident, not only of passing but passing with a good grade. She felt cheerful, almost light-headed, as if the future really did beckon.

As she got home she let herself into their flat and the first thing she noticed was the smell. In the bedroom her mother was propped up in bed, her eyes open but lifeless. She had a long dribble of vomit down her nightdress and, without pulling back the covers, Holly knew she had messed herself.

She spent a long time looking at her mother before opening her school bag and pulling out some latex gloves. Before she put them on she crossed to the bed and checked her mother's pulse, at her neck and wrist. She bent close to her mouth, for years immune to the stench of sick and worse, she watched for any breathing movement in the chest, listened intently for any sound of breathing and tried to feel any hint of breath on her cheek.

“Dead,” she said out loud. “Quite dead.”

She blew into the latex gloves and pulled them on. She picked up the tea mug and went into the kitchen. She washed the mug thoroughly and put it in the cupboard, then she rinsed a glass with water, leaving a small residue in the bottom.

As she came back into the bedroom she placed the glass in her mothers hand naturally and let it slip sideways onto the bed. All that was left was the final part.

In her own bedroom she retrieved the Amitriptyline packet she had hidden for four years. She scattered the empty packaging on her mothers bed along with the three pills she hadn't used. Holly made a small pyramid from the empty capsules, as if her mother had opened them and carefully set them aside. She smiled as she took a tiny amount of the powder she'd extracted from the capsules and laced a tiny trail inside the wet glass, looking for all the world like the remains of a toxic drink.

She looked around the scene, a scene she had seen in her head a thousand times, nothing was out of place. Nothing stood out.

As she dialled the emergency services Holly smiled as she remembered how she had persuaded her mother to go to their doctor. Just yesterday she had seen the doctor and told him how low she felt. How exhausted and hopeless. The doctor had 30 people in the waiting room and had suggested she make a new, longer, appointment so he could understand better.

An ambulance crew came, declared her dead, and went. The police came and went. Too understaffed to waste time on another dead alcoholic. Their local doctor came. He apologised and made arrangements. He said he would need to report the death to the Coroner but he was able to issue a death certificate because he had just seen his patient. He felt the coroner would not ask for a post-mortem.

It didn't matter if he did. Nobody knew the full circumstances of Holly's mother's death. Except Holly, and she wasn't telling anyone.

Chapter Four

It was three weeks after their first encounter and Finn and Adam were enjoying a meal together in a restaurant. It was a very expensive restaurant where everything seemed muted and discreet. As he sat down Finn's super-logical brain took over and he noted the perfect placing of all the cutlery. It was as if every knife, fork and spoon had been laid out with a ruler.

The perfectly white tablecloth looked like it had been ironed whilst on the table and the wine and water glasses gleamed like they had been polished lovingly. They had.

The Maitre D' had greeted Adam by name and said "Welcome back," as he escorted them to their table.

Finn watched Adam intently. He knew Adam was rich. He didn't have precise figures but he knew it included the word 'very', probably twice. He loved how Adam was so poised. Rich and privileged perhaps, but certainly not entitled. Not rude or crass. As Finn looked around the restaurant he could see several tables where the diners were completely dismissive of the staff. No please or thank you. No manners.

Part of Adam's upbringing, from his grandmother, was that he had attended a normal school, with normal people. Well, nearly normal people. A couple of Cabinet Ministers kids, a renowned concert pianist's son, a celebrity chef whose daughter had her own social media channels, and the children of one of the greatest rock and roll legends of all time. You know, normal people.

Of course there were many others, like Finn. Kids whose parents were working normal jobs from phone engineers to bank managers. It had been very grounding for Adam and, now, Finn was very grateful.

Finn smiled at Adam across the table. *The boy certainly has got class*, he thought.

“What are you smiling at?” Adam asked him.

“I’m smiling at you. No wait, I’m smiling *about* you.”

One of Adam’s eyebrows raised.

“You’re so relaxed, so charming, so at ease. There are people eating in here like it’s a way to brag to their friends. The food could be shit and all they care about is that they didn’t get the table near the toilets. But you seem to be enjoying it – the way it should be enjoyed.

“*And...*” Finn said emphatically “you appreciate the people working here.”

“Well that much is true,” replied Adam. “I might not have done much to earn my money in the first place but I do realise that people have to work hard and, if they are trying their best, there’s no need for me to behave like a dick.”

They enjoyed their meal. Finn was full of praise for each course, claiming that the latest one was easily the best thing he’d ever tasted. It was an evening of smiles and laughter... and maybe some low-level flirting.

Just before they ordered their dessert, the kitchen door opened and the chef started to circulate the restaurant, greeting each table, shaking hands, spreading Gallic charm.

Gabriel Laurent had trained in some of the finest restaurants in the world, and now he was building his own business. With two Michelin stars it was only a question of time before he added the coveted third. He believed in edible perfection, not TV shows and celebrity cookbooks. For him, food was the star and he chased perfect ingredients not wild concoctions and pretentious gimmicks.

The idea that a restaurant would give you Bluetooth headphones to listen to sounds of the sea while you ate your fish made him weep in despair and laugh out loud in equal measure.

It helped that Gabriel was gorgeous. He looked like a young Sacha Distel with hazel eyes that made you feel like he could bring you to orgasm just by looking at you.

Adam watched him for a moment while he spent a long time talking to an older couple. They seemed in awe, with good reason.

The last table to be greeted was Adam and Finn.

“Adam...” Gabriel held out his hand and greeted Adam warmly. His French accent meant he put the emphasis on the second A in Adam.

Adam introduced Finn and Gabriel shook his hand, holding it while he spoke. He looked straight at Finn, not blinking until just before Finn felt the need to laugh nervously.

“This is a good friend I think Adam. I like him.”

“I like him too Gabriel. I like him a lot” Adam smiled at Finn. “But tell me about the couple you were just talking to in the corner.”

“Oh I love them...” Gabriel lifted his hands in a very French gesture “It’s their 50th wedding anniversary. They know good food and wine but this is something they have saved up for and really enjoyed.”

He put both hands on their table and dropped his head conspiratorially “To be honest...” he whispered “I’d rather have a restaurant full of these people than the arseholes with expense accounts and no idea about good food.”

“So... could you organise a liqueur with their coffee, maybe a decent brandy? And a bottle of good champagne to take home, then tell them their bill has been paid by an anonymous customer.”

“Adam!! I didn’t know you were such an old softie,” Gabriel laughed.

“And maybe give them a signed menu and a copy of the bill with no prices so they can remember what they had,” Finn joined in.

“Hah! I knew you were a keeper. Adam you are generous but he is genius.”

Gabriel went off like a child with an exciting new toy. The boys watched discreetly as he told the people what was happening. They looked around but saw nobody looking their way.

When Gabriel went back to the table he had a bottle of Hennessy Paradis and he hand poured a large measure in two glasses. The couple held hands across the table while they sipped their brandy and coffee. So did Adam and Finn.

They ate their perfect dessert, both smiling for no good reason. It was just a perfect evening.

“Ummm... can we talk about the elephant in the room?” Adam spoke quietly.

“What, oh yes of course. We can split the bill. I can pay by card...” Finn felt slightly uncomfortable.

“No, not that.” Adam laughed out loud “I’m more than happy to pay the bill, after all I suggested this place tonight.”

“And it’s been memorable, for all the right reasons.” Finn smiled.

“It’s just that we’ve been out several times. We had coffee virtually daily, meals out, the cinema but we haven’t actually...” he left the sentence hanging.

Finn paused before replying, as if measuring his words carefully. “I wanted... I wanted something rare. I didn’t want some wham, bam, thank you sir. I wanted something that would last... be special.”

“Finn...” Adam started but Finn stopped him.

“I felt something real and long lasting with you. There felt like a real spark the moment we met but then I found out you were stupidly rich

and I'm just a normal working bloke and I thought you might think..."

"Oh fuck, Finn. I just wanted to go slow so I didn't mess it up. I felt a real connection with you but I was scared of pushing too fast."

"OK..." Finn said holding up his hand "let's just agree, amid all this stammering and stuttering that we are both stupid and that I really want you."

"Oh thank God, because I want you so bad I would even throw a load of coats on the bed! How about we recreate our first... encounter?"

"I would like that very much," said Finn with a grin.

"Come back to mine?" asked Adam.

"Perfect. Is it far? Finn knew Adam had a flat but they'd never talked about where it was.

"Errr... it's actually next door?"

"What? You actually live overlooking Covent Garden Piazza?"

"Pretty much. My Grandma told me to buy somewhere suitable but somewhere there was plenty of life. Next door came on the market, it was good for Uni and it's certainly full of life. I love it around here.

Finn sent his dad a quick message. "I'll be late or not at all."

His phone immediately pinged back "Just be *safe*. Call me if you need a lift."

Adam paid the bill with a very generous tip in cash. Finn had never seen such a large restaurant bill. He thought you could buy a car for less.

Adam's apartment was, as he said, just next door. The ground floor of the building had been converted into a retail unit but with the original windows of the 18th century building. It looked very upmarket.

"This whole building was originally one house but it was converted to apartments about 60 years ago and then completely refurbished recently," Adam told Finn.

Walking past the shop doorway they walked to an imposing door on one side of the building. Inside there was a small lobby and a lift door. Adam pressed the button and inside, Finn noted that there were no buttons, only keyholes. Adam inserted his key to the top slot and the lift started upwards.

As the door opened, another lobby had two front doors.

"On the other floors the lift opens directly into the apartment but I wanted to separate off another flat," Adam explained.

"Who lives next door?"

"Nobody, it's just a two bedroom flat I keep for visitors or, who knows, maybe I'll have a live-in carer when I'm old" Adam laughed as he opened the door to his flat.

From the entrance hall Finn could see ultra-modern stairs leading upwards and large double doors into a huge sitting room.

"Wow, that's bigger than my whole house," he said.

As they walked into the room Finn could see massive, comfortable looking sofas and a big modern kitchen along one wall. Above the kitchen was a mezzanine floor, accessed from the hall, with a modern desk and computer and a wall of glass doors leading outside.

"Oh my God, you have a roof garden too? It's breathtaking."

"Well... it's a bit silly really" Adam sounded sheepish. "I've got a posh kitchen and I don't really cook and a giant wine fridge but I don't really drink."

"This place must be worth millions," said Finn and mentally kicked himself as soon as he said it.

“Maybe, I don’t really know.”

Adam gave Finn a quick guided tour. There were three bedrooms all with an en-suite bathroom although one room was a well equipped gym. In the master bathroom Adam slid a mirrored cabinet to one side to reveal a shop-level stash of different, upmarket, colognes – including an unopened bottle of Pour Monsieur by Chanel. Finn just smiled at him.

Adam made sure Finn knew that from the far side of the apartment was a fire escape for emergencies.

“There’s only the lift where we came in, so if it fails or there’s a fire, you have to use these stairs.”

They both looked over the railing into the darkness below.

“Don’t worry” Adam said “there are lights that are motion sensitive so you don’t break your neck.”

Upstairs the office area led though to a sizeable terrace overlooking the piazza. There was comfortable seating and a lot of plants. It was like a private, secluded oasis. You could see and hear the activities below but nobody could see you.

“When we did the renovations I specifically wanted to build the roof garden but without overloading the structure of the building. It was chaos the day they craned the small trees up here.”

They leant on the parapet looking over the street performers, the people enjoying their evening and the general hubbub of city life.

Finn wondered if this was a design for Adam. Cloistered but on the fringe of the action. Discreet luxury but still in touch with normality. Private, independent, self-reliant.

It suited Finn, whose work by its very nature, could be solitary, but he really hoped there was space in Adam’s life for him. His life, and his heart.

Perhaps reading Finn's mind, Adam turned his head towards Finn and pressed his forehead against the side of Finn's head. As Finn turned their lips met, briefly, gently. The faintest whisper of intimacy.

With their faces just millimetres apart Adam spoke quietly.

"I want..." he stopped.

"I know" said Finn "I do too."

The next morning Finn let himself in at his own house. He went into the kitchen to get some cereal and his dad was sitting at the table eating toast.

"Did you have a nice evening?" Marc asked with a small smile on his face.

"Let's put it this way Dad. I've just run the mile and a half from Covent Garden in totally unsuitable shoes, laughing maniacally like a madman and might possibly have whooped a few times."

Marc laughed. "Does he feel the same way?"

"Oh God, I hope so. I think he does. We just seem to gel together but... early days"

"Invite him for dinner so we can interrogate him and make you both squirm."

"Not a chance matey. Well not yet, but soon though. Where's Steven"

Finn's dad was married to Steven Hawkes, a paramedic.

"He'll be home soon. He switched shifts with someone last night so we can have the whole weekend free." He punched his son lightly on the arm as he went past, "it means we can cook a nice dinner for your new boyfriend" He grinned at Finn.

"Look out of the window Dad, let me know how many flying pigs you see."

Chapter Five

It had been a very busy week for Finn and Adam. Finn had a major project in hand and confessed to Adam that he was one of those people who usually slept less than 5 hours a night. During a project his routine was driven and a little chaotic.

Adam had a full week of lectures and needed to work hard on his final thesis but between them they managed to carve out some time together. They had coffee twice and Finn walked Adam back through to his university.

They'd eaten messy pizza on the floor in front of the sofa in Adam's flat. It was an evening of low-lighting, quiet conversations and a lot of laughter. They decided they would redefine the whole concept of 'Netflix and Chill'.

"I thought we were at least to *look* at Netflix, not move straight on to chill," Finn laughed.

Finn had told Adam about his conversation with his dad when he got home after their first night. To his surprise Adam was all in favour.

"If I meet your dad at least I'll know what you'll look like in twenty five years time," he said.

"I don't know so much," Finn replied. "They'll ask all sorts of questions and go out of their way to embarrass us. My dad has always said it's the duty of a good father to embarrass his son at all times."

"Bring it on," Adam smiled. "I can take it and so can you. Besides, I'd quite like to know what a real family is like."

Finn considered that for a moment. They'd talked about how Adam felt he had a strange childhood. Both his parents were distant and it was only his grandma that anchored him. Not that Finn thought he had a classical family structure himself but he did know that his weird

four parent, two house upbringing was stable, secure and loving. He thought Adam would enjoy that, and might even survive.

“You’re on,” he told Adam. “Saturday night, come at 6pm and we normally eat at seven. Don’t bring anything except yourself.”

On Saturday Adam stood nervously outside Finn’s door. He was holding on to a bottle of red wine like his life depended on it watching his cab disappear up the street. He’s agonised over the wine, partly because he knew nothing about wine but also because he didn’t want to spend too much or too little. He’d either be a skinflint or a show-off.

In the end he’d just grabbed the same bottle as the man in front of him. Red. That’s all he knew. The extent of his wine knowledge. Deep down, he suspected that he was unconsciously avoiding any real knowledge of wine, alcohol in general really, because he had seen the devastating effect it had on his father. He vaguely remembered reading that there was a genetic factor in alcoholism and it wasn’t a trap he would let himself fall into.

As he reached for the doorbell, the door swung open and Finn was beaming with excitement. He pulled Adam inside and hugged him tightly.

“I’m so pleased you’re here” he whispered, his mouth touching Adam’s ear. He kissed Adam lightly on the lips and pulled him into the sitting room.

“Dad, this is Adam. Adam this is my dad Marc” he made the introduction then called out to the kitchen for his stepdad.

Adam held out his hand but Marc ignored it and stepped in for a hug. “Sorry Adam, we’re a whole family of huggers.” He held Adam out at arms length and they both took stock.

Adam could see the family resemblance in Marc. He was in his mid-forties and looked in good shape. Handsome features, like his son

and well-cut pure white hair. *Well if this is how Finn turns out I'll be happy*, he thought.

Marc took in Adam's short cropped hair and his dark brown eyes. They looked warm and kind and that was all Marc cared about. He wanted someone to make his son happy.

Adam sensed a movement to his side and looked around to the kitchen door. His head shot back in surprise. Finn laughed.

"I know, but don't be frightened he's not that scary."

Steven Hawkes was like a man mountain. Six feet five, possibly in both directions, and built like a tank. He was also model gorgeous with piercing blue eyes and muscles everywhere. He was wearing a polo shirt that looked like it could double as a car cover but he was also wearing a huge smile.

Good God thought Adam *this guy is a wet dream for lots of women and a few men*. He wasn't Adam's type but you felt like he should carry a big stick to beat off admirers.

He also swept Adam up into a hug.

"Don't worry, you'll get used to it," Finn told him. "It's like hugging a concrete bunker."

Once released Adam proffered his bottle of wine.

"I hope it's nothing too posh," Steven told him, "we're complete philistines here."

Adam had already taken in the stylish furniture, the muted colours and the artwork on the walls so he knew they weren't philistines but he was glad he'd gone quite middle of the road with his choice. Enough to pass muster but not enough to brag.

They all sat and chatted while Steven finished off dinner preparations, shouting contributions from the kitchen.

“It’s only a simple supper, nothing fancy” Steven called out “Just Cottage Pie with my added secret ingredients”.

“Now there’s a challenge Adam” Finn spoke quietly just to Adam and hisdad.

“Adam has this amazing sense of smell so I bet he can sniff out Steven’s secret.”

Marc grinned. “Well I already know but I bet Steven will be astounded.”

Steven called them to the table and brought in a large dish of minced meat covered in beautifully browned mashed potato.

“It smells divine” Adam told him “Is that Lea and Perrins Worcestershire sauce – the British trap for unwary Americans?”

Steven turned to Marc “Did you...” but Marc held up his hands in an innocent gesture.

“And oregano... fresh oregano.”

Steven laughed and said he had no idea what was happening.

“I feel violated,” he laughed. “All my secrets laid bare.”

They spent a long time eating and just sitting over the table chatting. Nobody was a drinker so, after a glass each, there was a little left in the bottle. Adam learned a lot about Finn and his parents.

Marc was a Detective Inspector with the Police. He’s already passed his promotion exams and felt Chief Inspector was on the cards soon. He was an expert in fraud, especially cyber-crime and ran a specialist unit focusing on domestic and international crime.

Adam was fascinated by Steven’s story. He’d joined the Royal Marines as a sixteen year old, the youngest age possible. As soon as he’d passed his thirty six week intensive training he requested training as a Battlefield Medic. Because of the competition for that role he spent four years as a Marine before he was accepted for

further training. Another four years of training and he had gained qualifications and very real first-hand experience.

Once qualified he made the decision to leave and become a paramedic in London. It was partly because he knew he was gay. He'd known going in and it had never been an issue in 8 years. Royal Marines didn't really care about that. You did your job, backed your mates and vice-versa.

But he knew he wanted something else. Stability, a relationship, a different life.

Within a month of arriving in London, he had met Marc... and Finn.

"And twenty happy years later, here we are."

"Wow..." said Adam "do you miss the Marines?"

"Not really, but once a Marine, always a Marine, so I go to reunions and stuff but I prefer my life now."

Adam got the impression that Marc and Steven had a happy, monogamous relationship. He was pleased to hear Finn had grown up in such a good environment. Monogamy was something that resounded with him. It's what he wanted. Stable, secure, forever.

They asked Adam about his grandmother. It turned out that Marc was a huge fan of her Inspector Griffin books.

"So did she name the detective after you and your father?" he asked

"Not at all," Adam replied. "my dad changed his name in the late 90's to match the character. Grandma didn't approve because she knew he had some sort of half-baked plan to cash in on the name. In the end, he was always too drunk to do anything about it"

"But you lived with your parents growing up?"

"Well, yes and no really. We lived together in the sense that we all lived in Grandma's house. It was this huge place in Knightsbridge and my parents would sort of come and go. Sometimes my dad

would disappear for days on end and my Mum would have an endless social whirl. The only constant was my grandmother and Lizzie the housekeeper.”

“Is the flat next door for when Lizzie is your carer?” asked Finn with a smile

“No but she’d be perfect for scaring any carers witless if I had them. Actually she’s just moved to a retirement village in Somerset now and is very happy”

“Just moved?”

“Yes, she had a flat in the basement of grandma’s house and didn’t want to move when grandma died. So I rented the main house to an embassy and it was a couple of years before Lizzie told me she would like to move on. So I sold the house and moved her into a lovely apartment in a place with loads of facilities... and other people. I think she just got tired of London”

“She must get a good pension” said Steven.

“Oh she doesn’t pay...” Adam replied and immediately blushed.

Steven recognised the discomfort and immediately said “So... who wants to see childhood photos of Finn? We got him in the bath, running naked round the garden and even... kissing a girl in nursery school!”

“No thank you” shouted Finn “nobody wants to see that. And anyway, that girl kissed me. I was confused, taken unawares”

Finn gently put his hand on Adam’s thigh and it was like a quiet whisper of reassurance, with a small part of seductive promise.

The whole evening was a roaring success. It was clear that Adam liked Finn’s parents and they liked him. He learned some interesting things about Finn, the most surprising was that Finn needed very little sleep. He was one of those people who thrived on less than four or five hours a night.

He also discovered that Finn had the most astonishing computer setup he's ever seen. Four monitors running simultaneously looking like they ran The Matrix, plus a laptop either side.

"I pay the electricity bill because I use more than everybody else" Finn had laughed.

"I still don't really know what you do," Adam said.

"Well, put simply, imagine you're a giant company and all your manufacturing, invoicing and logistics are computerised. You might have good security but, if someone got access, they could ruin your business, or hold you to ransom and shut you down till you paid. We get paid to test your systems and make sure it's as bullet-proof as it can be"

"Hence, you're the guys in the white hats?"

"Correct. Of course sometimes it's after an attack and we go in to repair damage and establish whether it was an inside job or a failure"

"and people pay you lots of money for this?"

"Well, you know... it keeps the lights on" Finn gave Adam a cheeky grin.

It was about 11.30pm when Adam ordered a car to take him home. Finn and his parents went outside to wave him off as a sleek Mercedes pulled up.

"I take it 'Shitty Cabs' didn't have a driver free" Finn teased him.

Adam gave him a peck on the cheek and left in a waft of luxury.

Back inside Steven pulled Finn and Marc into a hug.

"He's really nice" he said, his voice muffled by the hug. "I think you should try and keep him"

"I really like him and I think he likes me so... let's wait and see" Finn replied.

Marc lifted his head up from the hug and said “Although fuck knows what we would get him for Christmas” making all three of them laugh.

Adam got out of the car and crossed to his doorway as the driver did a three point turn because the main piazza is pedestrianised. He waved to the driver, who he’d met before, but more from habit or courtesy. Adam believed it was better to be nice to people because he felt most people were just trying to get on with their own lives and didn’t need pointless extra hassle.

There seemed to be a lot of people out tonight, even for a Saturday, so he shut the outside door firmly and then gave it a pull to double check.

In the lift he reflected on the evening. He’d had fun, he’d liked Finn’s dad and Stepdad and he thought they liked him. There hadn’t been any awkward moments. But the biggest plus was that Finn was there.

As he opened his apartment door he wondered if he was... what? Smitten? A crush? Something more? Adam hadn’t been ‘in love’ so he had no measure but he did know that every time he thought about Finn it made him smile. He looked forward to every meeting, no matter how brief, and then there was the whole physical thing, which Adam thought was just about perfect.

As he poured himself a glass of water to take to bed, he looked around the kitchen. Was it too tidy? Too clean? It would be nice to have someone to cook for, someone to moan about bad TV with, someone to share everything with.

What would his Grandma think? Well she was totally in love with her husband and they had shared everything. Would Grandma approve of Finn? Yes, she most definitely would.

He hoped Finn would be that person.

Chapter Six

Holly Foreman looked like any other person on the street in London. She stood quietly, just off Covent Garden, seemingly scrolling mindlessly on her phone but, because this was London, she looked up frequently, always aware of phone snatchers either on a bicycle or a moped. In fact it was a cheap burner, just in case. Holly didn't want to risk her real phone, which was tucked away safely.

Looking up frequently and scanning the area was a good excuse. She might look like someone idly scrolling whilst waiting for a friend but in reality she was paying careful attention to the shop across the road. It was easy really because the shop had large but old fashioned windows onto the street and was brightly lit. Holly knew they sold things she coveted. Nice things, but things that were beyond her reach. She knew from their website that they sold handbags that cost a year's salary for a nurse

Part of Holly was scandalised at the inequality but most of her wanted it for herself. Craved it.

She watched as a woman came out of the shop and carefully locked the front doors. The woman had short blond hair and very deliberately put the keys into her handbag. Holly thought it looked like she had a special, zipped pocket, just for those keys. The woman pushed the door again to reassure herself that it was shut properly and walked away from the piazza towards Charing Cross Road.

Holly didn't need to know the destination. There were many ways to walk to Soho from Covent Garden but they always ended up in the same place. A bar where this woman could enjoy a glass of wine without being hassled by men with dodgy chat-up lines. A bar frequented largely by other women, and some of their allies. A warm and welcoming place where you could just relax and be yourself.

She followed the woman cautiously at first but at a pace where she gradually caught up, about halfway along their ten minute walk.

“Hello Vivienne” she smiled.

The woman turned and smiled back “I saw you waiting. I’m sorry if this seems a little cloak and dagger but my company is very...” her voice tailed off.

“I know, don’t worry. You don’t want to lose your job because some rich customer thinks he has a chance with you”

Vivienne nodded, it was only half true but she let it go.

Vivienne Bridger worked in a very upmarket handbag store in Covent Garden. The sort of place with a locked entrance and a security guard.

Unlike the store she worked in, she lived in what was euphemistically known as a house of multiple occupancy but most would recognise it as a shithole. She had one room with a single bed, a bedside cabinet and a wardrobe. On her level there was a toilet and bathroom that she would clean thoroughly *before* she used it. She couldn’t remember the last time she had showered without wearing flip-flops.

There was also a small kitchen on her level, although she’s hardly ventured across the threshold. She barely ate, to remain as skinny as possible, thinking this was the look of a “luxury goods consultant”. It was just a happy coincidence that she felt sure her cooking facilities probably carried a public health warning.

In contrast to her living conditions Vivienne was always immaculately dressed. She scoured charity shops looking for donations from wealthy people, although those shops were much wiser to the value of designer goods nowadays.

She always left her room wearing a large trench coat because she felt uneasy about other tenants knowing how well dressed she was.

She walked to work in trainers across Waterloo Bridge, changed into designer shoes she had found for £10 and suddenly her world changed. This world was quiet, refined and understated.

At home she had unspeakable cooking smells and shouted confrontations between angry neighbours. Here, she had muted conversations and a mixture of best quality leather and a faint waft of Yves St Laurent perfume.

In many ways Vivienne couldn't understand why she worked in a shop. She was tall, model tall, with flawless skin and a ruinously expensive pixie hairstyle. Vivienne, by anyone's measure, was a beautiful woman

She felt like she belonged here, surrounded by luxury. Not there. It might have just been a job but she secretly fantasised about being whisked away by a super-rich admirer. The sort of man who would think nothing of spending fifty or even a hundred thousand in her store. A man seemed more likely although Vivienne knew a super-rich woman would suit her better.

Holly had cultivated Vivienne for weeks. She was part of Holly's backup plan.

Holly had been surreptitiously watching the store where Vivienne worked. She had seen her leave work in her trainers and walk towards the river. As soon as she got to the bridge Holly knew she was heading home. She followed her once to get a home address but normally she didn't bother. By coincidence it wasn't far from where Holly lived in a similar crappy room.

It was the second or third evening when Vivienne walked the opposite way that intrigued Holly. As she followed Holly realised they were heading towards Soho, the once-sleazy area of strip clubs, prostitution and rip-off 'hostess bars'. Now it was reborn with artisanal coffee shops, restaurants and gay bars - but still with a large number of strip clubs and rip-off bars.

Holly was intrigued but got her answer when Vivienne turned into a bar on Old Compton Street. There was a tough looking woman on security outside. Nothing menacing, just checking that people arriving were aware of the type of bar it was, and more than capable of repelling any unwanted 'lads' looking for a cheap thrill.

The security guard had nodded at Vivienne as if she was a regular. No need to make anything clear.

Holly didn't hesitate, she followed Vivienne in, with just a brief conversation at the door with security.

Holly had never considered herself anything other than straight. She'd never even thought of herself as bisexual or even curious. Her sexual exploits had all been fleeting, usually one night stands or maybe a weekend. At university she'd had a couple of friends with benefits but nothing complicated before or since.

She had never needed a relationship. She saw that as a distraction from her goal. There would be time for that later.

Needs must when the Devil drives, she thought to herself.

Holly was surprised. It wasn't at all what she expected. Actually, as she ordered a glass of white wine, she realised she had had no idea what to expect. It wasn't the tabloid shock-horror of 'alternative lifestyles'. There were no exaggerated stereotypes. There were just a bunch of women, and a few men, having a drink after work. Holly saw from a sign behind the bar that they only opened in the evening so she was among the first customers of the day. Maybe it got a bit more raunchy and cruisy later but currently it felt like a good atmosphere.

She smiled shyly across the bar at Vivienne.

It was actually their third 'accidental' encounter when Holly said "We must stop meeting like this" and laughed. Vivienne raised her glass in a toast and they had struck up a conversation. Holly was careful to extract information and feigned ignorance of Vivienne's workplace.

Holly was fit and, whilst she wasn't as beautiful as Vivienne, she was attractive. She didn't have Vivienne's sense of style but she worked hard to make herself attractive to Vivienne. She flirted and flattered in a completely natural and carefully understated way. Vivienne was being played and Holly was pushing all the right buttons.

A few dates later, not pushing too hard, but definitely moving along, Holly had suggested a hotel. They had been for meals together, drinks out and had had some discreet kissing and fondling. All within the relatively safe spaces of Soho. Holly had ascertained early that Vivienne was heavily closeted at work and scared she would lose job if they knew.

They had both told of the horrible places they lived in. Holly had described her place accurately but lied about the location. Accommodation in London, even across the river to a less fashionable area, was outrageous.

So Holly had suggested a hotel. Just across the river, away from the swanky West End hotels, there were budget hotels that were more affordable, still expensive but affordable. You got what you paid for and, although it was clean with a good bed and a good bathroom, there wasn't much by way of service. Of course, it was infinitely preferable to either of their homes.

Holly had surprised herself. She'd expected her responses to be mechanical and clinical but she diligently attended to Vivienne's needs in a caring and loving way. She was warm and affectionate. She was conscientious in bringing Vivienne to the brink and beyond.

Once you can crack sincerity she thought they will believe anything

If Vivienne suspected she was faking she gave no clue, even when Holly faked her own orgasm – more than once.

Vivienne was happy to be in a relationship, one where the other person understood her need for discretion and caution. So she was genuinely pleased to see Holly when she caught her up just as they

arrived in Soho. She smiled, apologised for being so uptight and closeted but they headed for a meal in Soho.

The meal was relaxed and enjoyable. Vivienne chose the meal with the lowest carb rating and they both skipped dessert. The conversation flowed as they talked about their jobs and background. Apart from admitting to being a nurse, nothing Holly said was true, not even the hospital she worked in.

She almost revelled in the fantasy she had woven. It was as if there was pleasure in duping someone so completely, even if they would never know.

As they left the restaurant Vivienne turned to Holly and said “this has been a perfect evening for me. Thank you”

Holly stared warmly into Vivienne’s eyes “and you are the perfect person to spend an evening with”

To Holly’s surprise Vivienne leant forward and kissed her softly on the lips. In the middle of a crowded street. In front of people.

They walked closely together through Soho.

“You know babe, I really envy you working with all those luxury things” Holly said quietly.

“It’s just a shop really”

“I know but I don’t even get to touch lovely things like that. I wouldn’t make it past the security guard. I don’t look rich enough” Holly laughed with just the right tinge of sadness.

Maybe it was the two glasses of wine or the need to nurture their relationship but Vivienne wiggled her eyebrows and said

“Well I do have the keys”

Holly stopped in her tracks as if shocked. She smiled brightly and hugged Vivienne tightly.

“Really? Oh my God that would be so cool. I just can’t imagine touching a thirty thousand pound bag.”

She jumped up and down, dragging Vivienne with her.

“Wait...” she stopped suddenly “you won’t get in trouble will you?”

“No” Vivienne smiled “even if somebody noticed I can say I forgot something and I can turn off the alarm and the cameras so no-one will even know we were playing”

At the shop Vivienne entered first and Holly heard the bleeping of the alarm and the code. Once she’d turned off the alarm and the internal cameras she beckoned Holly inside.

The lights were all on because they were on all night. Vivienne said if a police officer appeared she had ID and could show them the keys but she said it was unlikely.

They spent twenty minutes with Vivienne demonstrating different handbags and explaining the different types of leather and where it was from.

Holly picked up a pair of delicate pigskin gloves but Vivienne stopped her.

“Don’t try those on because you’ll stretch them and then you’ll have to buy them.”

“Are you saying I have big hands?” Holly laughed.

“No but they are made to mould to the hand of the buyer. It’s like not even wearing a glove”

Holly was genuinely impressed with the stock. In twenty minutes she touched, modelled and drooled over every handbag in the whole store.

“I’m sorry babe but all the excitement had made me need the toilet. Do you have a loo?”

Even before she'd engineered her meeting with Vivienne, Holly had staked out the shop from various angles and positions and established a rough layout. She already knew where the toilets were.

"Of course, I'll unlock the fire escape door and you can use that while I rebuild these displays for tomorrow"

Through the side door into a small lobby Vivienne pointed to the toilet door to one side of a staircase and went back inside. Waiting for the door to close, Holly waited a couple of heartbeats in case and then sprinted up the stairs.

Lights came on as they picked up the motion, she noted the light but she quickly arrived at the top floor.

She only needed a moment. She took out her phone and photographed the door entirely, the small landing and several close ups of the lock. She smiled to herself. *It's the same* she thought.

Holly had become a big fan on YouTube of the 'LockPickingLawyer' and various other instructional locksmith video providers. She purchased a kit from Amazon and several locks to practice on and she felt confident she could open most doors. She'd even bought herself an expensive electronic lock picker but she preferred the old-school method.

On a previous reconnaissance trip she'd established that the shop had a Banham Type III lock and duplicates were only available from the manufacturer to registered users. Also a brightly lit shop doorway in a busy tourist hotspot was hardly a good place to use her lock-picking skills.

Fortunately she discovered a side door that, from her observations outside, she assumed was an internal staircase. Like many emergency exits the inside was a wide push bar but outside there was a key operated lock. Holly had bought the same model of lock and had found it easy to open with her newly acquired skills and tools.

Now she knew that all the floors above used the same type of lock. Obviously from inside the apartment the push bar allowed a quick exit, they were sometimes called 'panic bars' with good reason, but the other side needed security and the builder had bought matching locks all the way up.

Holly raced back downstairs and took a moment to catch her breath. As she did, the door to the shop opened.

"Are you OK?" Vivienne asked.

"Yes, I'm sorry, I lost my bearings for a moment and nearly went through that door" she pointed to the outside door "would that have set off all the alarms going?"

"No it's not alarmed because it's shared with the flats above" Vivienne replied "it's only the internal door into the shop that's alarmed" Vivienne laughed "but you'd have been on the street outside with no way back in!"

Back in the shop Vivienne had tidied all the evidence of their playtime away and they were ready to leave. Behind the heavy wooden entrance door Holly pulled Vivienne close and kissed her.

"Thank you babe, this has been real fun"

Vivienne opened the door and Holly stepped out. There was a pause while Vivienne reset the security cameras and the alarm and then locked the door.

As they walked across the piazza, where they normally separated to go home, Vivienne touched Holly's hand and gently held her little finger.

"I'll ring you tomorrow" she said.

Holly smiled genuinely "can't wait" she said

As Vivienne walked away she was happy and had no idea that it was the last time she would see Holly.

Holly watched her walk away and she discreetly pulled the SIM from her burner phone and snapped it in half. As she walked through the piazza she dropped the phone through a drainage grate and a few yards later dumped the SIM in the next one.

Happy that her backup plan was watertight she smiled as she walked past the street entertainers and tourists. They just saw a happy woman in her thirties walking and smiling. Maybe she'd just been on a good date, maybe she was just happy.

She had no plans to ever see Vivienne again. She hoped it wouldn't be necessary because she couldn't imagine Vivienne becoming a loose end. But if she needed to clean up any loose ends, she had a plan for that too.

Chapter Seven

Marc Williams walked upstairs to his son's room. He knocked and waited for a reply. They had always had an understanding of mutual privacy. When he got a response, he went in. Finn was sitting at his desk looking intently at rapidly scrolling figures and numbers on one screen.

"Just the man" Finn said excitedly "I've got something for you to investigate. You know, the *legal* sort of investigation."

"Well I need to talk to you about something, but you go first Finn" Marc said.

Finn pointed to a big pile of printed sheets on his desk. "This is an 'unofficial' investigation into a company called West Marsh Sportswear"

His dad frowned "and by 'unofficial' you mean totally illegal?"

"Can we call it a grey area?" said Finn with a smile.

"We can call it a bloody giraffe, but it's still illegal"

"OK. If nothing else it's untraceable information that you might find is a starting point for a proper 'legal' investigation" Finn made air quotes for 'legal' but was still grinning. He knew he had gold-plated information and it was his dad's job to obtain the same data by legal means. If nothing else he was giving his dad a route-map to a successful conviction.

Marc grunted, which Finn took as a signal to continue. It wasn't the first time they'd had that conversation.

"So, I'm doing some work for an unnamed bank in London, ostensibly I'm looking for security weaknesses but I have uncovered some flaws in their money laundering systems. Big flaws"

Finn paused but he knew he had his dad hooked. There's nothing a fraud investigator loves more than a good money laundering scheme to investigate.

"We both know that, regardless of what they say publicly, banks in London have a lot to do with illegal money laundering. At best they'll blame human error and get a slap on the wrist from the regulator. But this is pretty big Dad"

"Is this likely to damage your relationship with the bank?" Marc asked.

"Highly unlikely. There's only maybe half a dozen people in the world that could make a link to me. There's me, the three people I work with and two others. I've got enough dirt on those two to put them in jail in at least 10 countries around the world."

"Let me show you on the screen, it's easier" Finn continued "West Marsh Sportswear is a limited company set up in 2020. It was the height of the pandemic so maybe they just opened up with little scrutiny. All their paperwork though was in tip-top order. They operate out of a small warehouse in west London, just off the motorway, with nice easy access to just about everywhere in the UK."

He flicked an image on the screen of an anonymous looking warehouse unit taken from across the road.

"Did you take this photo?" Marc asked.

"You know I never leave my room" Finn laughed "No, it's a camera on the building across the street"

Finn flicked to another image, this time the huge roller doors to the warehouse were open.

"What strikes you here?" Finn asked.

"It's empty?" Marc replied.

“Bingo, in fact every image over the last 30 days with the doors open, you can see it’s empty. The storage company opposite only keeps their data for 30 days but I have started a backup for them in the cloud”

“OK, so... unsuccessful sportswear company.”

“Not so unsuccessful. According to their official account, available in the public domain, the company has annual revenues of £20 million. Pretty successful. But here’s where it gets murky”

Finn pulled up a collage of still images from opposite and other cameras, all showing various vehicles pulling up outside. Always at the weekend.

“But here’s the mother-lode” Finn said “Video from inside the warehouse itself. Honestly these people need to sack their IT bloke. I think there are corner shops with better firewalls and security”

Finn pulled up video clips of people walking across the empty warehouse carrying in nondescript sports bags. In the back of the warehouse were two large desks each with a large cash counting machine. Each person would empty a bag and watch as a pile of cash was put through the counting machine. Then the counter would enter it into a ledger on the desk and the visitor would sign.

“I’d like to get my hands on that ledger” Marc said quietly.

“Well I haven’t got that but I have got some other records printed out for you. Bank statements going back to 2020 that show somewhere in the region of four hundred thousand being paid in cash into their account every Monday morning. It’s crazy. They actually have a proper armoured security van come to the warehouse and take the cash to the bank”

“So they leave all that cash lying around all weekend?”

“Well yes, but not unattended. It’s quite heavy” Finn pulled up an image of two men sitting at the far end of the warehouse drinking tea. On the desk, between their tea were two semi-automatic rifles.

“Oh-oh” Marc smiled. “They aren’t normal security guards are they?”

“There’s more,” Finn pointed to the pile of papers on his desk. “All the payments are in cash. There are no records of them ever selling a single sports shirt by credit or debit card. In fact, as far as I can see, they have no merchant accounts set up at all to accept plastic”

“It’s unlikely, but not impossible that they only take cash. County fairs, trade shows. It’s a stretch but...” Marc was looking at the security men on screen, he knew this was an illegal operation.

“Highly unlikely Dad, but also I’ve got details of their payments out of the account. There isn’t a single payment to a clothing manufacturer. No payment to traditional clothing manufacturing countries even. Nothing to Thailand, Bangladesh, Indonesia. In fact all the payments out are to shell companies in places like the Cayman Islands, Panama and Belize. None of which are noted for their sweat shops.”

“OK, let me check through your stuff. We’ll have an official look when I get a ‘tip-off’ from an official informer”

“So you’ve got a friendly snitch to get the ball rolling?” Finn grinned.

“We’ll see” his dad replied “I just need to get it right so it doesn’t fall apart in court”

Finn looked around and saw the laptop his dad was holding.

“Is that something I’ve done wrong or something you’ve done wrong?” he grinned.

“Neither, it’s about Adam”

Finn sat upright, all his attention focused. He knew his dad and he knew that his serious face meant serious business. Marc pulled a chair from the side of the desk and sat down next to Finn. He gestured to Finn to move his keyboard so he could put his laptop on the desk.

“Do you remember the day you met Adam?”

“Vividly, even though we vaguely knew each other at school”

“Well, you said a van mounted the pavement and nearly ran him down. Someone in the crowd apparently said they thought the driver was on the phone. Remember?”

“Yes, lots of people milling around. Someone said a kid was driving. Someone said a girl. Either way, some idiot driving much too fast for the station delivery road.”

“Well here’s the thing. Something was niggling at my brain so I checked on incidents for that day and an abandoned van was recovered and towed away. Turned out it was stolen”

Finn’s eyes narrowed but he said nothing.

“So I managed to pull up the CCTV footage for that day from multiple cameras.”

He opened the laptop and Finn could see a CCTV image from cameras around the station. Finn knew that London had more security cameras than any other city in the world and, in these circumstances, he was pleased about that. He understood the counter-argument but he was clearly in the ‘if you’ve done nothing wrong, you’ve nothing to fear’ camp.

He also knew that, as a senior police officer, his dad would have access to a lot of that footage.

“So... here is you and Adam, quick reactions by the way, well done, and the van mounts the pavement just at a point where it would hit Adam, but for you. It swerves back onto the road, crosses into the oncoming lane for cyclists and pedestrians, hits the back of that bike before screeching back to the left and out of sight.”

They both watched the silent scene play out.

“But this is more interesting” Marc continued “the van turns left out of sight, until you bring up this footage about a hundred metres away.”

Again they watched as the van drove, slower now, along the road and turned right. Marc flicked the video to another clip. The van pulled over, half on the pavement. Totally illegal, even for a delivery driver.

“Watch carefully now” Marc instructed

The van remained stationary for a few moments until a group of tourists squeezed past on the pavement led by a large gentleman holding a big golf umbrella aloft. Then the passenger door opened and someone got out and joined the group.

“The driver waited” Finn said.

“Exactly! We know from the previous clip there was only one person in the van so this is the driver getting out on the wrong side deliberately to mingle with a crowd.”

The short road where the van was abandoned led up to the river and a major London tourist attraction, The London Eye, a massive Ferris wheel visited by more than 3 million people every year.

“We lose the driver in the crowds but there is a short part of the clip where I am convinced it’s a woman. You can tell by her gait, the way she moves. Then we just lose her in Jubilee Gardens and the South Bank. She probably pulled off the hood and it’s harder to spot. It was a busy day but she had disappeared into the crowds on the South Bank before you’d even dusted yourself off.”

“So why does this concern Adam?” Finn asked.

“On the face of it, not at all. It could have been a stolen van and a planned robbery that failed, or they chickened out and made a run for it”

“Except...”

Marc took a deep breath.

“Adam said about a month earlier he’d fallen on the tracks on the tube”

“Yes... actually he said he felt the crush of people had pushed him off the platform. There had been an England football international match at Wembley that day, a huge rock concert at the O2 Arena and some sort of protest march in town and everybody was congregating in the centre. There were so many people on the platform he just got shoved”

“Absolutely, it was a chaotic night. Strangely enough there is an offence called ‘Endangering Safety on the Railway’ and people that survive under a train, even failed suicides, are often charged and convicted”

“Stupid law” snorted Finn

“Well, certainly a stupid way of enforcing it. Anyway Adam was *not* charged because, I reckon, the powers that be knew they had mismanaged the crowds and endangered safety, resulting in Adam’s fall”

“He won’t, but he should sue” Finn muttered, mostly to himself

“But the Devil is in the detail” Marc said “I got the platform CCTV and the footage from the driver’s cab”

He cued up the new clips and as it ran he said

“Adam was lucky and unlucky that night. He was unlucky that he was at a station without platform screen doors, which stop people falling off the platform, but he was lucky that it was a really old station. The older, deeper, underground stations have a pit between the rails. It’s for drainage really but it’s known as the suicide pit. Actually it’s an anti-suicide pit because some lucky victims fall down the pit and, like Adam, the train could pass completely over them”

“Blimey, the things you never realise” Finn let out a big huff of breath.

“Watch this clip from the drivers cab” Marc told him “The train is slowing for the station and, just as Adam falls...” he paused the video “it’s hard to see but there is a person right next to Adam. A dark green hoody and a blue surgical mask”

It was a stretch to make out anyone in the less than perfect footage but there clearly was someone.

“All the other people jump a mile as Adam falls. But not this person. People start pushing back to make some space. The train stops really quickly and people shout down to see if Adam is OK.”

“Fuck, that is scary” Finn could feel his heart pumping.

“What you can’t see, is that figure in the green hoody. I’ve checked an hour after the event on different cameras and the surrounding streets. Nothing. Whoever it was, they didn’t stay to help and, more interestingly, they must have switched the green hoody as they left.”

“Maybe they used the emergency stairs?”

Most people, especially visitors, don’t realise that in addition to the escalators up and down there are emergency stairs. Often big spiral stairs and usually dimly lit, cold, damp and quite scary.

“Quite possibly but either way, they just disappeared. Probably deliberately”

Finn looked sideways

“You don’t change your appearance and use the back stairs if you’re just a shocked witness who doesn’t want to be involved Finn”

“Wait, are you saying...” Finn started but his dad interrupted.

“I’m saying we need to talk to Adam. It could be a coincidence but it’s also possible someone tried to murder Adam.

“Twice” said Finn quietly.

Chapter Eight

Adam and Finn sat drinking coffee early the next morning barely acknowledged by Maltese Tony who was polishing the espresso machine like his life depended on it. Adam had lectures quite early so they were among the first in the door. Finn laid out the information his dad had told him. Adam was quiet, pensive.

“I can see how it all fits together but I can’t understand why someone... anyone, would target me”

“I know, it doesn’t seem logical. Have you had any other odd experiences? Online contact? Ex-boyfriends? Anything out of the ordinary?” Finn asked.

“Nothing. Apart from you, my life has been pretty dull. Lectures, coffee and home. That’s it.

The cafe door opened and Holly walked in. She was already wearing her waitress uniform and, having just finished a night shift, she was cursing her double life. Seeing Adam and Finn, her eyes narrowed and she took off her hoodie and hung it behind the counter before rushing straight over with a vase of ‘fresh’ plastic flowers.

“What*will* you think of us?” she said to Adam smiling “letting you sit here with no flowers on the table”

“Hello Nikki” Despite his conversation with Finn, Adam was his normal polite and courteous self. “Don’t worry about it, we’re only here for a quick coffee”. He smiled inwardly at the waft of alcohol hand wash and latex gloves that always followed Nikki around.

‘Nikki’ bustled away to start serving other customers. What news might she glean today, she wondered.

Adam smiled at Finn “ I think I need an early night to digest all this info and I’ve got lectures all day today. How about we meet up at

6pm for a quick pizza or something then I can be home and in bed by eight.”

“Got it” Finn laughed “Quick pizza and we can be in bed by eight”

“Nice idea but I really need to think and process so I’ll be Billy No-Mates at home and if you’re lucky I’ll call you to say goodnight.”

They waved goodbye to ‘Nikki’ and Maltese Tony, who looked at them like he was being forced to throw £20 notes from a car window.

On the pavement outside Finn laughed “Maltese Tony is more ‘hostility’ than ‘hospitable’”

“I know. I genuinely think he would step in to help if you needed it but he’d moan about it for evermore”

They parted with a quick hug and a plan to meet later.

Adam’s day was a confused mess of partially understood economics and complete bewilderment about who would want to do him harm. He mentally reviewed every personal interaction he’d had over the past few months, years even, from dates to meetings with lawyers and business people.

He didn’t think fans of his grandmother’s books were likely to be crazed psychotic fans but... well he just didn’t know. There were still millions of fans around the world. Her books were still popular because they evoked a bygone age, a gentler time, when even murder had a softer edge. He racked his brain, sifting through plots of oft-read stories looking for links, perhaps recreations of a plot of a scenario but came up blank.

He thought it was inconceivable that a fan somehow had it in for him.

The one thing he did know is that he was looking forward to seeing Finn. It had only been a few weeks but somehow he felt he’d been waiting for Finn for years. They just seemed to gel together, both physically and emotionally. Not for the first time he wondered if Finn was ‘the one’ – the missing piece of Adam’s jigsaw. All he knew for

sure was that every single time he thought of Finn, it made him happy.

Finn had spent the day working on a report detailing why a large multi-national car manufacturer was in danger. He spent twenty minutes pondering whether to claim a 14 year old 'script-kiddy' could break into their servers with ease. In the end he decided that it was true, and justified.

He'd finished his report with a series of recommendations for their IT people to implement urgently and, in case they didn't have the skill-set, a price estimate for Finn and his colleagues to make it more secure. He emailed the report, along with a pretty eye-watering bill for the work so far.

During exchanged messages during the day Adam and Finn agreed to meet for a burger and met at 6pm at a place offering 'gourmet burgers'. They decided they were just normal burgers instead of the crap served up by the fast-food places.

During their meal there had been some sly, almost shy, smiles and some flirty banter. It was Finn who broke first.

"You're not really going to send me home all alone are you?" he asked, pulling a sad puppy dog face that made Adam laugh.

"I'll tell you what." Adam replied "How about you come home with me as my bodyguard. Then you can give me a good frisking for hidden weapons"

"Sounds perfect" Finn said "and we can talk about any evidence that comes up"

"But I do need a fairly early night, Finn. I've got another full day of lectures today and I need to try and work out what I was supposed to have learnt today"

"No problem. Once you've had your wicked way, you can push me out into the cold, dark streets"

They were happy walking through the streets, shoulders touching, laughing and just enjoying each other's company.

Holly had practised this move a hundred times. She picked the lock with ease. The side door to the fire escape was sheltered from easy view from the main piazza and not visible to any cameras. She cracked the door open slightly and listened intently before deciding the ground floor was clear. She opened the door and slipped inside. From her experiments in her room, with the panic bar she'd bought online, she knew the bar rattled noisily when opened so she slipped a small wooden wedge she'd made, into the opening. It was perfectly sized so the door looked shut from inside and out but a simple, silent, push would enable her to leave unnoticed.

There was a light on in the shop and, though the small pane of glass in the interior door, she could see Vivienne on the far side talking to a customer. She slipped up the stairs quietly. She knew lights would come on as she went up but that didn't worry her.

She had a cover story in case another resident came out of another flat. The shop downstairs had told her the toilet was through the door and upstairs – but she didn't need that. In staking out the apartments she was fairly sure all three flats were unoccupied at the moment.

On the fourth floor she crouched over the lock and quickly picked the lock open. *Thank God for the Internet*, she thought.

She stepped inside confidently and then, in the darkness, she waited.

Finn and Adam walked through Covent Garden piazza thronged with crowds. There were some after-work drinkers enjoying a quick 'reviver' before heading home via commuter-hell. There were people meeting for a meal in one of many restaurants, many tourists just soaking up the atmosphere and some teens wandering aimlessly in that '*excited to be in London but no money to actually do anything*' way. The street entertainers were out in force and they stopped briefly to listen to a passable song from Les Miz. Adam gave the

singer £5 and told Finn he'd actually been in the piazza the night a good singer had been approached by a woman passing by and they had sung a duet from Phantom. It turned out the woman was a professional and was currently playing Christine in the Phantom of the Opera just around the corner.

As they approached Adam's door, Finn discreetly looked around at the crowds but nothing out of the ordinary stood out. They kissed in the lift but it was lovey-dovey smooching rather than passion, which made them both laugh.

They were still laughing and talking as Adam was opening the apartment door. Finn felt Adam stiffen. He held a hand up to Finn. He didn't need to speak. Almost imperceptibly Adam breathed slowly through his nose. His eyes darted around from the entrance hall, up the stairs and into the sitting room.

"Something is wrong" he whispered to Finn "Someone is here. I can smell something like... bleach?"

Finn reached to the side of the front door and ran his hand down a big bank of switches. From that panel you could turn on every light in the apartment.

With all the lights on they started to search. Adam had said he would search upstairs but Finn made them stick together. Upstairs, outside on the terrace, the bedrooms and the kitchen, they searched everywhere.

Finally, back in the sitting room Adam said "the fire escape?"

As they approached the fire escape door neither of them heard the soft, silent click as the lights went off. Finn pushed the door away from them and, before the motion detector kicked in they both stared into the darkness. As Adam stepped forward to look down the stairs, the lights came on but there was nothing to see. They listened intently for a moment but there was no sound.

Finn bent down and picked up a small wooden wedge. He held it out to show Adam but Adam just shrugged.

“No idea” he said softly.

Back in the apartment Adam asked if Finn wanted a cup of tea. There was no reply and as he turned to Finn he saw Finn was staring at the kitchen worktop.

“Adam... for someone who never really cooks it struck me as odd that you had so many knives but...”

Adam looked at the wooden block standing on the work surface. There were eight slots to hold the extremely sharp knives safely but now, there were only seven knives.

A knife was missing.

“I’m staying here tonight” Finn said quietly.

Holly walked briskly through the piazza. The crowds irritated her, getting in the way, posing for selfies and generally being touristy.

“Fuck, fuck, fuck” she muttered to herself. “Fucking tourists. Fucking changes of plan”

Holly had keyed herself up for the finale of her scheme. She had mentally worked through the scenario a thousand times. She would wait in the dark, Adam would come home alone and she would use one of his kitchen knives to stab him. When she was sure he was dead, she intended to stage the room as if Adam had disturbed a burglar and, in the ensuing struggle, the burglar had snatched up the knife and stabbed Adam through the heart.

A tragic end to a simple burglary. Probably some crazed junkie or maybe a professional thief who panicked.

“He was supposed to come home alone” she said out loud. She had considered killing them both but she wasn’t confident she’d succeed once she lost that momentary element of surprise.

Holly knew that security would change at the flat. Maybe new locks, maybe internal bolts.

“I need a new plan” she told herself “but either way... Adam Fucking Griffin is a dead man.”

Chapter Nine

Billy Fish was a small-time crook. Barely even a criminal in truth. He was really just a trader with the occasional foray into illegal goods. He had no criminal record, although he'd been arrested a few times, but he definitely knew all the right players in the criminal underworld.

Knowing the right people meant Billy traded information. He was like a broker, putting people in touch with people – for a small fee. If you needed a reliable driver for a robbery – Billy knew someone. Need someone to enforce a debt – Billy knew someone. Need to fence a stolen Rolex watch or a big box of iPhones – Billy knew someone.

Nine times out of ten Billy wasn't even involved directly. He just took a small fee for the introduction. He told his wife he was like Tinder for scumbags.

Billy Fish wasn't even his real name. He'd been born David Chubb. His parents lived in a small flat in central London rented from a charitable trust. They both worked in a posh London hotel and his dad had a nice little sideline as a bookies runner. In the early 1960's betting shops became legal but as a young hotel bellboy David's dad would take bets from wealthy hotel guests and visit a seedy office just off Piccadilly to place them. The tips were good and, if there was a substantial win, the tip was normally very good indeed.

Later, even though betting shops were everywhere, he would still take bets for people who didn't want to be seen in such a low-class establishment.

David decided at a young age that he wanted more. All through his school days he was known as Fish almost as soon as someone worked out that a chub was a type of fish. For a long time he was Dave Fish but then some bright spark decided Bill Fish sounded better.

So for all of his life he'd been known as Billy Fish. Except at home. In the leafy north London suburb where Billy lived with his wife and daughter he was David Chubb an upright business owner who imported ceramics and dinnerware to supply London hotels.

David Chubb and Billy Fish led two separate lives and, apart from his wife and daughter, nobody would realise the connection.

Billy operated out of an old factory just off Bow Street, not a stones throw from Covent Garden. The location and its connection to London's earliest police force always amused him. The factory originally made wire coat hangers but had been long abandoned when he bought it.

It was probably worth millions now as a redevelopment site but Billy had bought it nearly 40 years ago when the area was less fashionable. He had paid cash, in the days when fewer people questioned cash. In fact it was financed by what Billy thought of as his four proper criminal acts.

He'd been part of a three man team who had robbed the wages office of a large factory south of London. In those days wages were paid weekly in cash so it was just a question of timing. They had split the money four ways with 50% going to 'Mr Big' who had organised everything. Then working on his own, Billy had robbed a post office and two betting shops, always targeting cash only.

In all four cases only Billy knew that the ancient World War 1 revolver he was waving about had no bullets. He relied on speed, shouting and audacity.

He used the cash to buy the factory and turn it into a small warehouse. His shelves normally carried whatever was in vogue at the time. Currently he has a large stack of air-fryers. People assumed they were stolen goods – 'hooky' was the word the locals used – but in reality Billy had bought them legitimately from a near-bankrupt importer. As long as people thought they were getting a bargain, Billy saw no reason to tell them.

Billy hated mornings so he normally got to work around midday and left at 8pm so he was sitting at his desk at 7.30pm when the doorbell rang. The building might be 200 years old but the security systems weren't. Billy pulled up the camera covering the front door onto his computer screen.

"Oh for fuck's sake" he muttered.

It was raining steadily but staring back, directly into the camera lens, was Detective Inspector Marc Williams.

"Are you on your own?" Billy demanded over the speaker.

"Yes Billy just open the bloody door"

Unknown to anyone except Marc, Billy and a senior officer at Scotland Yard, in addition to all his other business interests Billy was a snitch, a grass, or to use the official police terminology, a Covert Human Intelligence Source and Marc was his officially designated contact point.

Marc had known Billy from his very early days as a police officer. When he became a detective he had recruited Billy as an informant and, although Marc had moved on to more specialist work, neither he nor Billy wanted to get him reassigned. Although not that active nowadays the small bits of intel that Billy provided were normally passed on to other officers.

Marc wasn't naive and knew that a lot of Billy's tips included shutting down some competitors and exacting revenge but overall he was a good, reliable source.

"Hello Billy" Marc called out cheerfully as he made his way through racks of shelving stacked with everything from 'I love London' t-shirts to plastic wrapped trays of energy drinks with dodgy looking names. "How are Carole and Anna?"

Billy bristled a little because he didn't like people to know about his family but he smiled, almost warmly, before replying.

“They’re good. Carole has taken up Pickleball or some other bollocks and Anna is nearly finished with her Doctorate”

“When she finishes university and gets a real job you can give all this up and retire” Marc was still smiling. He didn’t realise it but that was exactly Billy’s plan.

“And miss out on all these jolly little, unannounced, visits? I don’t think so.”

Billy was immensely proud of his daughter’s achievements. She had studied Economics at Oxford and been accepted as a post graduate student studying for a Doctorate at the London School of Economics – one of only twenty places available. She’d already been approached by several banks with job offers. He was confident that, when she was settled, he could sell up and Carole and he could retire to their very nice house in Spain.

“Anyone see you coming in?” Billy asked.

“No Billy, it’s not my first day mate”

Billy grunted an acknowledgement so Marc continued.

“I need you to give me some information about a money laundering operation called West Marsh Sportswear” Marc told him.

“Never heard of it” Billy shook his head. He had genuinely never heard of them but it was difficult to keep track of all the barbers, nail bars and phone shops that were involved in money laundering these days.

“Write this down” Marc said, pointing to the notepad on Billy’s desk. He proceeded to dictate the company name and address, registered number, bank details and a brief breakdown of their activities. All straight from his head, Marc had nothing written down.

As Billy finished Marc said “So, I got some intel from an unregistered, unofficial source but I can’t act on it without a tip-off from someone I can attribute it to.”

Billy tore off the sheet of paper but held it close to his chest "How much?" he said flatly.

"Just the pleasure of helping you local police" Marc said.

"Then the local police can stick it up their arse"

"Seriously Billy, you know the drill. I'll register it as your tip-off and, if we get a successful conviction, you'll get a payout. Probably a big one, if this is as big as I think it is"

"Done" smiled Billy, handing over the sheet of paper.

Billy checked all the outside cameras before Marc slipped away into the rain soaked streets.

As he started to pack up for the day Billy considered if there was a better way to earn money from the information about West Marsh Sportswear. On balance he decided to let it be. Some things were just too much aggravation when you were approaching retirement. He took a last look at the cameras and silently cursed the rain but it was only a short walk to the tube station for his journey home.

He pulled on his coat, set the alarm, locked up and left for the night. He left all the lights on because he felt it made the place look more occupied. *Fuck the planet* he thought *and fuck any scumbag that wants to break in.*

Walking through the streets in the rain Marc contemplated the information about Adam's break-in. Was it a simple burglary that had been disturbed before it started? There were certainly scratches on the locks that might indicate a lock-pick but who could know when? Were they just being paranoid because of a couple of previous incidents? Marc didn't like coincidences and there was nothing wrong with a dose of paranoia sometimes. He had organised a security expert to give Adam's apartment a once over and make any changes but he realised they needed to do more.

Unbeknownst to Marc, on the opposite side of the street, walking the opposite way, Holly Forman was heading to where Marc had just left.

She had heard a whisper in the cafe that Billy Fish could procure anything for a price, or at the very least point you in the right direction. She'd followed Billy back to his building because she didn't want to talk to him in, or even close to, the cafe.

She noted the lights on but there was no response when she rang the bell. She rang several times, getting more agitated and frustrated. Billy's phone buzzed an alert as he sat on a tube train heading north towards home. He looked at the images sent from his cameras.

He recognised the waitress he knew as Nikki but they had never interacted before except on the most basic level. He had no idea what she wanted or how she knew where his office was. Billy could have used his phone to talk over the intercom but he decided not to. *Whatever she wants can wait, he thought.*

Holly walked away as the rain started to fizzle out. She wasn't sure what she had expected – certainly not office hours – but she had expected him to be there. Somehow, with no real logic, she expected nefarious work to be done at night.

She was angry as she walked away. Nothing was going right for her. All her hopes and plans were being thwarted. Everything she was hoping to achieve was either out of reach or getting put off. She was frustrated with herself and she was angry with Adam. He was the roadblock on her path to happiness. With him gone, she could finally be at peace.

She needed to be bold, she told herself. She needed to be decisive and act quickly. There was no time.

In reality her plans would have been better given some more time and planning but she was so obsessed with getting what she thought she deserved, she was blinded. All her actions so far had been too impulsive, too badly thought through. She was failing because of her impatience and her failure was making her angry. The anger made

her even more impatient. *Damn it she thought I deserve better. I have been made to suffer and they had to pay.*

60.6 %Chapter Ten

Surveillance on the West Marsh Sportswear warehouse had started more than a week before. There were high definition cameras set up on adjacent buildings and across the road. In the car park of the warehouse opposite an old Audi estate car was parked facing the entrance to the target. What looked like a normal dashcam was in fact a high definition camera sending wireless signals back to the control point.

Around the back of that warehouse was an older van with the name of a removal company on the side. By coincidence it was parked close to a self-storage facility so it didn't look out of place.

Inside the van were two men who were watching a bank of monitors. Everything was being recorded digitally with instant backup to a cloud server.

It was fortunate that they got on so well because it was cramped and uncomfortable.

There was a tacit agreement about leaving or arriving at the van so there was a large 4 litre water bottle that had been designated the toilet. Fluids only and each shift took away their own waste.

George Blair was a Detective Sergeant with 15 years on the force. He was bright and intelligent with a high level of skill in technology. He was easily capable of promotion and had been badgered by senior officers to go down that route. But George was happy in his work and with his position in the machine. He also knew that the next rank up, an Inspector, didn't get paid for overtime and currently George was earning a fortune in lovely overtime pay.

George knew that another 15 years and he'd get a full pension and he'd only be 50. He couldn't draw his pension until he was 60 so that gave him ten sweet, overpaid years working as an IT security expert for a bank.

Sitting next to George was a younger man. Detective Constable Brandon Drake had joined the police straight from university at twenty one. He had a degree in Computer Science but had studied Accountancy on his own to a point where he could easily have passed professional exams.

Unlike George, cyber-crime was his passion. George was doing a job but Brandon was a fervent enthusiast. He paid attention to everything George said and did. He absorbed information, techniques and tips like a sponge. Not just from George – from everyone around him.

Brandon was aware of his own limitations. He had hated his first three years as a police officer. It was generally accepted that a new officer needed to spend at least three years in uniform dealing with everyday crime. Tall and stick thin Brandon was not the officer you'd want helping you to break up a pub fight but he was surprisingly good at calming situations and comforting victims.

Some unkind officers laughed at him, suggesting his name was more like a porn star even if his appearance wasn't up to it. Those people stopped laughing when Brandon passed his National Investigators' Examination with the highest score in 43 years. That had been part of his detective training programme and on completion, his life changed.

Unknown to Brandon, Marc Williams had been following his career for a long time. As soon as he was qualified, Marc called in favours, cajoled, manipulated and nagged until Brandon was assigned to his team.

George's phone vibrated on the desk in front of him. He answered, listened and just said OK before hanging up.

"Let the boss in" he said to Brandon who was closest to the door.

"Good afternoon chaps. It smells remarkably fresh in here."

Before George could reply Brandon chipped in “George keeps lavender sprigs in his underwear and he’s not allowed to fart till he’s at home”

They all laughed and George said “Cheeky fucker”

“It’s his wife I feel sorry for Brandon” Marc joined in. This was a good team and Marc knew it. Deeply technical and skilled but they also got on well together.

“So... give me all the good news” Marc said.

George had called Marc earlier and asked him to come to their surveillance point.

“Well, we had a stroke of luck about two hours ago. As you know last weekend we only had confirmation that deliveries were being made and a security van collected something on Monday. We’ve had several hits of people of interest, known bad boys, mainly in the cocaine and heroin business”

George started to move his mouse around the screen to bring up a video clip.

“Then, this happened” George hit play and they all watched as the footage from the battered Audi showed a Land Rover Discovery pull up and park just across the street. The driver got out and opened the rear tailgate. As he pulled the anonymous looking sports bag out of the car it snagged on something and a waterfall of paper bundles fell to the ground. The ultra high definition camera easily picked up that they were bundles of cash. You could even make out that they were held tight together with red elastic bands.

The driver quickly scanned the street, saw nobody and guiltily scooped the cash back into the bag. Then he crossed the small car park and entered the warehouse.

“What do you think, boss? Enough for warrants?”

Marc paused for a moment "It's enough to hit this place and probably the bank but it doesn't put our three principals in the frame does it?"

"Ahhh... about that" Brandon smiled. "Because one of our principals is a foreign passport holder, from a country with long and proud links to terror organisations, our warrant for this surveillance included permission to monitor their online activity"

"But there's no evidence of any terrorism links is there?" Marc asked although he already knew the answer.

"No evidence at all but the judge obviously decided to gloss over that technicality" George laughed.

"Our three principals all use VPN's..." Brandon continued. He was referring to a 'virtual private network' where your online activity is masked allowing you to browse anonymously.

"but one of those principals apparently misunderstood the purpose and, as far as I can tell, only uses it to look at porn. I've got him making various payments to tax-havens worldwide."

"One down" said George, who already knew this information.

"The second guy is much more careful but on one occasion I assume he thought he was safe but he wasn't connected so I've got him on one count"

Brandon looked pleased with himself. "Oh by the way, the first guy might surf the net anonymously but he's got some serious shit saved in his wank bank. I think we'll need rubber gloves to inspect his laptop"

"How about the third guy?" Marc asked.

"Totally secure sadly" George said.

"As far as I can see we have two choices" Brandon summed up "we can pick up everyone and try and get the two we've got to roll over

on the third man. Or we can wait and see if number three makes a mistake.”

Marc had already decided but wanted to quiz Brandon. “what’s the drawback of waiting?”

“Well, the VPN company is in the United States. They will not normally keep logs of who is connecting to what but we could, with the cooperation of our US ‘allies’...” Brandon made air-quotes “get a warrant to make them log the information and then disclose it.”

Brandon wrinkled his nose like it was a bad idea “to be honest it would take about a hundred years to get any action going and it could all fall apart by then. And, as we know, the more people involved the more likely it is to leak so the bad-guys could just bugger off to Dubai or somewhere with no extradition”

“Great job both of you. Monday morning we’ll hit this place at 5am and simultaneously pick up the other three at home. We’ll get armed support in all four places, especially here for the guys with machine guns”

“Machine guns? Who said machine guns?” said George

“What? Oh, educated guess. They won’t be guarding a big pile of cash with a catapult and a big stick will they” Marc kicked himself for the momentary lapse. They had no official evidence of any automatic weapons even though they knew there were guards all weekend.

Marc drove back into London. He knew it was only close to the end of the beginning. He would spend the rest of the day compiling the evidence and presenting it to the Crown Prosecution Service. He felt sure they had enough but sometimes it was an uphill struggle.

They would shut down the money laundering service, a few people would go to prison and everyone in his team would get a pat on the back. The bank would get away with their participation with some desperate mangling on the rule-book. Maybe a low-level patsy would

take the fall or maybe the Regulator would issue a strongly worded statement about tightening up their procedures.

Sometimes it felt like trying to stop the tide. They would maybe divert it a little but the real villains would get away scot-free. At 04.59am Marc issued a command over the radio and four teams advanced onto their target. By far the largest team was at the warehouse and Marc, George and Brandon were all armed but part of the second wave behind the officers from Armed Response Vehicles.

Marc's team carried standard issue Glock 19 pistols but other officers were armed with Heckler & Koch MP5's. Marc had referred to his note from his informer who claimed there would be two guards armed with automatic rifles. Nobody was taking a risk.

In the event there was no huge issue. The police entered the building quickly and efficiently with lots of shouted warnings. The security guards turned out to be ex-military and not paid enough to start a battle with armed police officers.

As they were taken into custody Marc noticed they both wore latex gloves. He suspected that there would be no fingerprints on any weapons found. That alone would shorten their sentences.

Back in his room Finn watched the build-up from the camera across the road. It wasn't as clear as the surveillance cameras but it was enough. He'd arranged to meet Adam at 9am but he was already wide awake. He didn't officially know that the raid was taking place, Marc would never have told him, but he surmised it from a series of events. Not least, Marc leaving the house at 3.30am.

As they moved in Finn switched to the internal camera. He tutted because their useless security irritated him so much.

He watched his dad moving around the warehouse. Pistol drawn initially and wearing a bulletproof vest.

Finn was equally scared for him and immensely proud of him. His dad looked like an action hero but Finn knew he also enjoyed a cuddle on the sofa watching a movie.

“God, I love that man” he said out loud./n/nUnheard by Finn, Steven had walked through the open door behind him and watched the scene over his shoulder.

“Me too” said his stepdad.

Chapter Eleven

Holly had finished her night shift at the hospital and had a 20 minute walk to the cafe. She had started to vary her route on the days she worked, becoming more and more convinced that she was being followed, or at least watched. Today she had walked along Holborn Viaduct into Lincoln's Inn Fields before heading south towards the cafe.

She endlessly replayed her previous failures, obsessively worrying at the mistakes, the bad luck and the might-have-beens. Unconsciously she had taken to muttering under her breath. Inaudible babbling that had raised eyebrows in both the hospital and the cafe. On one level Holly knew she was losing the plot but she held on because all she needed was one quick result. One lucky break.

Holly was frustrated and angry that Adam hadn't been to the cafe for days, nearly two weeks in fact. After her failure at the apartment she had arrived back at her room, closed the door, leant back against the door and just banged her head hard until a neighbour shouted at her to stop.

She knew that she had blown a good opportunity and, even if Adam thought it was just a burglary, he would have beefed up the security on that access point. She felt a simmering fury at being denied, being blocked from her rightful reward.

She was being hindered at every turn but deep down she knew she needed to retreat, take stock and regroup. Let the dust settle, she had told herself. Reclaim the advantage. Once there was enough time passed she could reformulate her plan and strike again. This time...

Holly was walking past the Student's Union building of the LSE when she saw him. Adam Griffin!

Adam Griffin, looking relaxed and casual. Tall, good looking and obviously happy, he was just standing around waiting in the street.

“Happy?” Holly muttered under her breath “I’ll give you fucking happy”.

She turned and ducked down a side street where she could watch unobserved.

It was 9am when Finn had agreed to meet Adam at The World Turned Upside Down. The 13ft diameter structure was a globe balanced on the north pole. It was a local landmark, albeit a controversial one.

Adam had arrived early and waited in the morning sunshine. He smiled to himself, thinking about Finn. Everything was going so well with Finn. They just seemed like the perfect match, almost complete compatibility. There were a couple of niggles, like Finn’s insistence on splitting every bill. It was like Finn was wary of Adam’s money, or rather the idea that he was only there for the money.

Adam genuinely didn’t care about the money. He knew Finn wasn’t a gold-digger and he knew he was falling in love with him. He was fairly sure Finn felt the same way although neither of them had said anything yet.

Finn was also much more concerned about recent events. Adam was prepared to write it off as a couple of weird coincidences but Finn was convinced it was something a lot more serious.

At Finn’s insistence Adam had bolts fitted to the fire escape door from his apartment and the street door downstairs. Finn was surprised Adam could do that on the shared door and even more surprised to discover Adam owned the whole building. After a fire inspection and an insurance company visit it was all settled. Finn felt more relaxed. He still insisted Adam spent a lot more nights at his house but that might have been for other reasons.

Finn was crossing the road when he caught sight of Adam. *He's a good looking guy, he thought.* Adam had an air of calm tranquillity, as if nothing would ever faze him. Finn often thought of himself as a jumble of thoughts wrapped up in a bustle of activity but Adam calmed that, soothed him. Finn could concentrate with laser-like intensity but he needed someone to help turn that laser off sometimes.

He had a sudden image in his mind of him and Adam as old men sitting on a park bench holding hands. He smiled, he liked the idea. A lot.

Some sixth sense made Adam turn as Finn approached. They both broke into wide smiles as they hugged. No huge public displays of affection although they knew nobody would care much there but just a hug.

As they pulled apart, a boy their age walked past. He was wearing a sage green hoody with a Stone Island label on the left arm. Adam called out "Hey, nice hoody twinsy". Adam was wearing the same hoody and the boy smiled and waved as he walked past them.

"Must be a rich kid" Adam whispered to Finn. "I hope it's not a knock off because mine cost 500 quid!"

Across the street, Holly came back into view. She'd moved behind a parked car when Finn arrived in case one of them noticed her watching. She squinted her eyes as if that might help her hear their conversation but she was too far away.

Adam and Finn had a full day planned. They were hitting the gym, followed by an exercise class. Upper body followed by mainly cardio Finn had explained. Then back to Finn's house to make a family dinner for the evening.

"I've just got to collect something from 32L and we can be off" Adam said.

"32L?" Finn asked.

“Sorry, I being all studenty” Adam cleared his throat and announced formally “I have to visit the Sir Arthur Lewis Building at 32 Lincoln's Inn Fields to collect some paperwork”

He grinned at Finn “Seriously it's only a five minute walk and I'll be two minutes inside”

“Such a dick”

They walked together, as usual close enough to rub shoulders and talk quietly. There were lots of students around going backwards and forwards because the London School of Economics had many buildings and lots of facilities.

“Cross the road” said Adam “you'll be able to see the building much better.

As they looked back Finn saw a monstrous piece of extravagant Edwardian architecture, full of the confidence of Empire.

“Wow, it's like Downton Abbey on steroids” said Finn.

“I know, it's wild isn't it.” Adam replied as they stopped opposite the incongruous entrance. It was a flat roofed, modern blob. Like a mangy dog sitting casually next to a Grand Duchess. Whatever you thought of the main building's architectural style – at least it had some, unlike the new entrance.

“Hang on here, I'll grab my stuff and we'll be off”

Finn watched as Adam crossed the road and disappeared into the building. He couldn't help running his eyes over the exterior of the building. He felt it had a strange familiarity, probably a TV location he thought – the London home of Lord and Lady Hobnob no doubt.

There were so many people going in and out Finn decided to cross over to be closer to the entrance. He didn't want to miss Adam. He took out his phone and checked for messages.

Inside the two sets of double doors there was a reception desk that had the effect of squeezing the passing visitors into a tighter flow. Just beyond was a noticeboard giving locations to facilities and some toilets.

Holly pushed her way back into the throng from the toilets and headed out of the building. Two seconds later the toilet door opened and a blood splattered body staggered out and fell face down on the floor.

A girl screamed, people backed away, many started heading for the doors. Inevitably some people started filming.

Finn heard the scream and saw the rush towards him. His heart froze but his body moved. With an enormous effort he pushed forward against the flow.

Just past the reception desk he could see a body on the floor. Dark hair, jeans and a sage green hoody.

“Oh fuck” he said out loud.

Two students standing nearby, doing nothing, were wearing Palestinian keffiyehs, the traditional black and white headgear. Finn pulled them both off and stepped closer to the prone body.

Kneeling alongside the body he pulled it by the shoulder to turn him over.

It wasn't Adam. It was the boy from earlier – the hoody twin.

Finn was on auto-pilot. He recognised it wasn't Adam but he still needed to help. The boy's hoody was completely unzipped so Finn put his finger into the hole in his t-shirt and ripped it open. He roughly folded one of the headscarves into a pad and placed it over the stab wound in the boy's chest.

“Oi! We're supposed to be going to a demo you know” said one of the students.

“Fuck off” said Finn vehemently. “Go and get me more cloths”

“You!” he shouted at another student “Stop filming and call 999. Put your phone on speaker and let me speak them”

Finn could feel the adrenaline coursing through him as he barked instructions to the receptionist.

“I want first aiders here straight away with a stab kit if they have one, oxygen and a defib just in case. NOW!!”

Instructions given Finn turned back to the boy on the floor. He had opened his eyes and was staring at Finn. He looked scared.

“My name is Finn. What’s your name?”

“James” came a weak reply.

“OK James, there’s good news and bad news. The bad news is you’ve been stabbed. The good news is I’ve done a first aid course” he grinned at James and there was the faintest glimmer of a smile on James’ lips.

“I’ve got the emergency services on the phone” the girl with the phone said.

Finn looked up to speak but the phone was taken out of the girl’s hand. Finn moved his head around – Adam. Finn could have cried.

“I need a paramedic A.S.A.P. We have a casualty with a stab wound to the chest, bleeding heavily but conscious and responsive.” Adam gave location details and the call responder confirmed a paramedic had been despatched. He knelt down opposite Finn with James between them.

“James...” said Finn “it’s important you understand what is going on. We need to stem the flow of blood but it’s also important to keep you conscious and stop you going into shock”

James nodded slightly. Finn continued “The blood flow isn’t spurting so it’s not an artery. Wrong colour too. We need to keep you awake

and alert because if you pass out either me or my boyfriend will need to give you the kiss of life”

Finn pulled a face of distaste and James actually laughed quietly.

“Well done James. Stay awake to avoid the horror” Adam joined in with a laugh.

Finn pressed a second headscarf to the wound. The first students arrived back carrying an armful of headscarves and other cloths. Finn felt a pang of guilt at being so mean to them.

“The great news is you’ll probably have a really cool scar when they stitch you up” Adam continued.

“Your girlfriend will think you’re a hero”

James’ eyes widened, looking momentarily scared.

“Or boyfriend, that’s cool”

James shook his head slightly but neither Adam or Finn understood.

In the distance they could hear a siren. The cavalry.

Adam jumped up and got a pile of books from the reception desk. He carefully propped James’ feet up on a stack to help lift his legs. “It helps with shock” he said to Finn, who just nodded.

Finn was just moving the next pad into place when there was a disturbance in the air. The crowd of morbid onlookers parted as a powerful voice rang out “Paramedic”.

Nobody in the crowd was touched but they all moved instinctively out of the way of the walking landmass that was Steven Hawkes.

“Finn? Adam? What the...” he exclaimed before clicking back into paramedic mode. “Keep doing that Finn, while I set up”

Finn had never experienced it but he had heard Steven say a paramedic will usually let a first aider carry on, if it’s being done well, while they get all their equipment ready.

“Adam, what have we got?” Steven asked.

“His name is James, he’s conscious and responsive but the bleeding looks to have lessened. He’s determined not to pass out because Finn said one of us would do the kiss of life”

Steven held James’ eyes open while he shone a torch.

“Good news James. I think you’ll escape the kiss of life”

“Will I be able to play the piano after this?” James asked.

“Absolutely no reason why not” Steven replied.

“Wow...” James said with a faint smile. “I couldn’t play before”

“What is this? A bloody comedy club?” Steven laughed. “OK, I’m going to get you patched up temporarily and there is an ambulance on the way to take you away”

Steven took over from Finn and quickly started treating James. It was efficient and professional. Finn wondered how often he’d treated stab wounds. Probably a lot in London.

“James, I’m going to use a haemostatic dressing. It’s designed to help the blood clot quicker and stem the bleeding. Then we’ll get you to hospital” Steven was calm and reassuring, explaining everything as he worked.

There was a small crowd on the pavement when the ambulance loaded James into the back. Steven had arrived on his specially modified motorbike, which is why it was such a fast response.

In the crowd Holly watched. She’s seen the motorbike arrive, the police – a lot of police – and then the ambulance. She was hoping to see a body bag loaded into the ambulance but she saw the prone figure was responding to the crew. *Damn* she thought *damn damn damn*.

Then she saw Finn and Adam emerge from the entrance doors. Adam! Alive and well. She could have screamed at the top of her

lungs. She could have run across the road and beaten him with a rock. The world was turning against her. She couldn't understand why this was happening to her. She didn't deserve this. She had hated Adam Griffin before but now her entire being raged against him.

What had been a cold, calculated mission was now a red-eyed monster.

She watched as the giant paramedic pulled them to one side. He talked to them both.

"Finn, your dad will be here in two minutes. Just get in the car and go home, both of you. Have a hot shower and make some hot chocolate. Something odd is going on... apart from the obvious so don't talk to anyone without your dad or me there. I'll bring a Chinese takeaway home at about 6pm."

"OK, no problem"

They were standing in the entrance next to a recycling bin for aluminium cans. Adam and Finn's eyes moved as one, as if coordinated, to the shape half hidden behind the bin.

It was a kitchen knife with a 4" blade. A perfect match for the seven remaining in Adam's apartment.

Chapter Twelve

Holly was having a bad day at work. A colleague told her she looked like she had been partying all night – a veiled reference to Holly looking worn out and scruffy. Later that morning she'd been reprimanded by a senior colleague for setting out the wrong medication for a patient. Fortunately her error was spotted before it was administered.

In reality she hadn't slept much last night. Another failure was weighing on her mind. The irony of fate conspiring against her and now she felt sure the police would be on to her by now. She imagined every single CCTV camera in London would be pointing her way

How could she have been so reckless, so unplanned and unprepared? It had taken all her willpower to stay in the crowd after the stabbing. She *needed* to know but she felt that the crowd were about to turn and point to her at any moment. She was sure that everyone knew who the attacker was and they were just waiting for the right moment to tell the police. It had been an agonising wait.

As she stood, watching Adam leave the hospital, she could hear her mother laughing at her.

"Just like I always said" her mother told her "useless and a complete waste of oxygen"

Now at work Holly was beginning to feel slightly calmer. Still agitated and irritable but less focused but with less internal noise. It was as if the world had had the sharp edges removed.

Holly was the assigned nurse to a young man admitted with alcohol poisoning. It wasn't his first visit and Holly knew it wouldn't be his last. The poor man was a chronic alcoholic and was being treated for the withdrawal symptoms with benzodiazepine. Holly had simply

replaced his medication with a couple of pain-killers from her pocket and taken the benzodiazepine herself.

It's just to stop me spiraling, she told herself. To clear my head of all the negative energy and hopefully give herself some head space to formulate a plan.

As she sat, gently rocking back and forth on her chair, the fuzziness and the brain-fog cleared. Like a ship sailing from a mist bank she had clarity. The negative, nagging voices disappeared. The doubt, the suspicion and the fear had gone. She had the perfect answer.

Adam and Finn had stayed overnight at Finn's house. There had been much discussion about the stabbing and how it might relate to Adam. Other officers were investigating but Marc was getting unofficial feedback.

When they announced that they wanted to visit James in hospital, Marc was wary.

"What's going on? What aren't you telling us?" Finn asked.

"Let's just say James is a bit high-profile and that explains the large number of police for a stabbing"

Eventually Marc agreed but only if they got one of Adam's posh cars there and back and no detours.

As they left the car Adam commented on the armed police officers outside the main entrance but they entered unchallenged and checked at the reception desk. There was some confusion because they only knew his first name and his wound.

As they walked towards the lift Adam said "High profile eh?" in a stage whisper that made Finn laugh.

The lift was crowded as they pressed the button for the fifth floor. As the lift doors opened at the second floor to let someone out Finn looked towards the Nurses Station, right opposite the doors. He frowned. It was 'Nikki', the waitress from the cafe.

He wasn't sure why but, as 'Nikki' started to look up towards the open lift doors Finn swivelled his head and kissed Adam on the lips. They didn't really do public displays of affection so Adam jumped a little and banged his head on the lift wall but the back of Finn's head concealed both their faces.

Thoughts were clicking in Finn's brain when he heard a middle aged woman say "Well, really..."

Finn grinned at her and said "Oh come on madam. I've never met this man before but look at him. He's perfect!! Who wouldn't want to snog his face off?"

There was some suppressed laughter in the lift and the woman turned to face the doors. She got out at the fourth floor.

Adam had blushed slightly but he nudged Finn in the ribs. "I'll make you pay for that" he whispered.

As they got out on the fifth floor Finn whispered "Something odd just happened but I'll tell you later".

Adam frowned but they headed down the corridor to James' room. Again, there was an armed officer outside the door.

Armed police? Private room? Is James a secret member of the Royal Family, thought Adam.

The policeman asked their names and spoke into his radio. Apparently getting an OK, he opened the door and ushered them in.

James was in bed wearing one of those awful hospital gowns that gave no dignity. A girl in her late twenties sat by the far side of the bed and jumped a mile when they entered.

"James..." called Adam "you look brilliant. Are you sure you didn't fake the whole thing?"

James greeted them enthusiastically and introduced them to his girlfriend who was called Anna. After shaking hands with them both

Anna immediately went back to holding James' hand.

"Any news about who, what, why yet?" Finn asked.

"Not really. At least nothing I've been told. My Mum is a bit protective so she thinks the worst"

"What's the worst?" Finn asked.

"Well probably that it was a terror related attack aimed at her."

"Why would she..." Finn started but James interrupted

"She's the Foreign Secretary" he said flatly.

Suddenly all the police cars at the scene, the armed guards and the private room fell into place.

James' Mum was Margaret Brand the UK Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs – most often known as the Foreign Secretary. She was a big noise in the UK. Probably second only to the Prime Minister and wildly popular with the people. She was tipped to be the next Prime Minister and a potential leader for the next 15 years.

Margaret Brand somehow blended a tough, unyielding stance with humour and warmth. She was a seasoned politician, probably right enough of centre to appeal to the voters being swayed by far right rhetoric and empty promises of a return to glory, but equally not so far right that she would scare the left and the liberals.

At university James had a Close Protection Officer to take him and collect him but not inside. It was to give him a semblance of normality but he worried that would be changing soon.

"James I have something to tell you, because it will probably come out soon" Adam looked intently at James and put his hand on his arm. "I should apologise because I think I was the target of your attacker"

“You? But why would anyone want to hurt you?” Anna spoke for the first time.

“Damned if we know to be honest Anna, but there have been a couple of incidents. This is the first time someone has been hurt” Finn replied with a shrug.

“So.... She might have got you but for me being in the wrong place?” James said.

“She?” Adam interjected.

“Well... I think so. It all happened so fast. I went to the toilet and, as I came out I saw a flash of something from the corner of my eye. As I turned I felt a thump to my chest and, as I staggered against the wall, I got a quick glimpse of someone in a hoody and a surgical mask. I’m fairly sure it was a woman”

Adam and Finn shared a momentary glance.

“The doctor said if I hadn’t turned at just that moment the knife would have hit my heart and killed me. As it is, I’ve got some muscle damage and a very cool story to tell my mates” James laughed.

Anna let go of his hand and slapped the back of his wrist. It was clear they were both relieved it hadn’t been a lot worse.

“I got you a present as an apology” Adam said to James. He lifted up a bright red carrier bag and James struggled to look inside with one hand.

“Stone Island?” he smiled

“I couldn’t get the sage green so I went with a mid grey”

“Adam you really didn’t need to do that”

“I know but... well, it could have been me”

At that moment the door opened and a man poked his head in, he surveyed the room and crossed quickly to check the bathroom. He

went back and held the door wide.

Bodyguard thought Finn.

Margaret Brand entered and Adam genuinely thought a light had been turned on. The sheer force of this charismatic woman filled the room with energy. Anna jumped a mile again.

“Mr Griffin” she held out her hand to Adam.

“Adam” he said.

She turned to Finn who pre-empted her greeting. “Finn” he said, smiling.

“Yes, I know something about your past employment” she smiled.

“What are you doing nowadays?”

Finn answered briefly and she had a couple of follow up questions. Finn thought the questions were astonishingly focused. It felt like two more questions and she could do his job as well as him.

“And Adam, what plans do you have after graduation?”

“I will just concentrate on running the family business”

Mrs Brand nodded but this was information she already had.

“I wanted to thank you both personally for your part in my son’s misfortune. I understand it was also quite a family affair” She looked at Finn but it wasn’t a question, she already knew.

“Yes, the paramedic who responded is my step-dad”

“and quite a hunk I believe” the Foreign Secretary said, and grinned at Finn before continuing

“I wonder if I could ask you both to wait outside for a moment while I have a word with my son?”

Anna stood as they moved to the door.

“Not you Anna.” Margaret said kindly. Anna and James exchanged a look. Nobody had introduced Anna before, her name hadn’t been mentioned.

“and please, feel free to hold James’ hand again” Clearly nothing escaped the attention of Margaret Brand but suddenly she sounded like a Mum instead of a powerful politician.

As they moved out into the corridor and away from the armed police officers, Adam saw Marc walking towards them. He nudged Finn.

“Dad? What are you doing here?” Finn asked.

“Summoned from on high.” he grinned. Amongst other qualities, Marc was not overawed by power, rank and privilege. “When the Deputy Commissioner rang me I thought he was going to pass out he was so on edge. I think I could have asked him to drive me over.”

“No prior notice though” Marc continued “so it was blues and twos all the way and I’ve left Brandon downstairs in a No Parking zone”

“Blimey” said Finn “talk about ‘when I say jump’”

“So you know who we’re seeing?” Adam asked.

“I knew who the victim was yesterday. Let’s just say some people got a bit of a kick up the arse yesterday. None of my lot though”

“Your biggest concern is that she thinks Steven is a hunk,” Finn laughed.

“I’ll fight her toe to toe” Marc put his dukes up.

They talked quietly about very recent discoveries while waiting.

Inside the room Margaret Brand held out her hand to Anna. “You must be Anna Chubb. I’m pleased to meet you at last”

Anna shook her hand, slightly confused. She had been in a relationship with James for just over 12 months but neither wanted to involve their families. James didn’t want to because of the whole

circus that surrounded his mother. Anna had never introduced James to her parents because she didn't want to cause any tabloid scandal if it came out that he knew her dad.

There were other considerations. Anna was over 7 years older than James. Not really an issue when you're both in your fifties but more significant when you are 21.

"The government has many good opportunities for Economists Anna. We really should talk when you finish your Doctorate." This was a softer, less tough persona. This was a woman talking to her only son's partner – a family member.

"James I understand why you kept your relationship from me but, if it's to go anywhere, it can't be hidden away like some grubby little secret. Anna, perhaps you could come for the weekend if you're free and my husband and I can get to know you better? And vice-versa of course. We don't bite!"

Margaret laughed and Anna couldn't help but laugh along with her.

"Of course, one thing we'll need to discuss is your father's retirement, Anna. The son of a future Prime Minister can have a relationship with the daughter of David Chubb, businessman – but she can't really have a relationship with the daughter of Billy Fish can she?"

Both James and Anna's eyes widened in amazement.

"Do you know everything mother?"

"I know about the important things James. You are important to me because I love you. Anna is important to you and therefore she's important to me"

James eyes softened "The nurses told me you were here last night while I was asleep"

"I was here for a while, yes."

“From midnight to 5am I was told. You must be exhausted.”

“I just needed to be close to you. To make sure you were safe” she said softly.

And that was a secret weapon Margaret Brand possessed. She was charismatic. She was tough and fearless. She was fierce and steadfast. And, at the same time she was compassionate, loving and devoted. Not for her the crocodile tears of other politicians. Not for her the fake sincerity and bare faced lies. Margaret Brand was a fighter and she'd fight as well for her country, as she would for her family.

Chapter Thirteen

The bodyguard and the armed police officer were joined by a younger man. He looked harassed and agitated and was popping from foot to foot. Marc, Finn and Adam were 50 feet down the corridor.

“Spad” said Marc quietly to the two boys. Adam and Finn both looked at him blankly.

“Special Advisor – basically a Minister’s assistant. Some are just flunkies but others are pretty powerful.”

He nodded down the corridor “He’s probably got an Economics degree from the LSE” and he winked at Adam.

At that moment the hospital room door opened and Margaret Brand stepped out. The Spad leapt at her, whispering in her ear.

“I’ll be here another ten minutes,” she replied, not bothering to whisper “I’m sure they can wait. It’s hardly trivial that my son is in hospital.”

The advisor scurried down the corridor, dialling on his phone as he went.

“Inspector Williams,” she called out “thank you for coming.”

Marc thought it wasn’t the right time for a joke so just acknowledged her greeting.

“Let me bring you up to speed on what we have – although it’s not much”

“I’ve been on the phone this morning with Counter Terrorism, MI5 and your Close Protection Team,” Marc told her. “I genuinely think it was a case of mistaken identity because Adam was the real target.”

“That seems to be the prevailing opinion I’m hearing” Margaret said “but, honestly we keep hearing that London is the surveillance capital of the world and, if I believed anything on TV, I would think we can do facial recognition from a mile away when someone is wearing a Mickey Mouse mask”

“I think it’s just a combination of bad luck, poor location and a lot of people,” Marc ventured.

“Hmm... maybe” Margaret Brand didn’t sound impressed and Marc had an image of her peeling a strip off several people and he was glad he wasn’t on that list. “All that top end surveillance equipment and no clues. The best we’ve got is some mobile phone footage from inside that we’re working on.”

“I intend to follow through with this, Inspector. Whether my son was the target or not. I understand that facial recognition from the street has already eliminated a group of people we already know about but there are a lot of unknowns.”

She smiled and held her hand out “We’ll both keep each other looped in I’m sure. Good work on the sportswear company by the way. It looks very promising. You were discussed in Cabinet this morning and it was all very complimentary.”

They all shook her hand as she left with her bodyguard. No doubt her Advisor would be somewhere close by, fretting.

“I have to run too,” Marc said, although Finn noticed he didn’t share a lift down with the Foreign Secretary.

“We’re just going to wave goodbye to James and Anna and then Adam can call his posh car service. We’ll probably walk down the stairs to time it for the car arriving.”

Adam looked sideways at Finn but said nothing.

A few minutes later, on the staircase, Finn produced two surgical masks. He picked them up in the corridor because they are freely available post-Covid.

“Put this on” he told Adam “ and this.” He delved into his jacket and pulled out a knitted hat. He passed it to Adam and put on a baseball cap of his own.

“What’s going on Finn?” Adam asked him.

Finn explained as they walked downstairs.

“When I kissed you in the lift it was because the doors opened and I saw someone I knew. You know your favourite waitress Nikki? Well she works here as a nurse.”

“Not really a surprise. I’m sure lots of nurses have other jobs. It’s scandalously underpaid.”

“I agree,” said Finn. “But why would a nurse work at a cafe when she could do agency work and earn a lot more? Most hospitals need to fill in staff shortages with agency nurses. Those nurses earn a lot more than their regular shifts so it doesn’t make sense to work long hours for minimum wage in a cafe.”

“So, why not tell your dad?” Adam said

“Because it’s just a hunch, a tingle, a weird feeling that something doesn’t add up.”

He threw up his arms in a gesture somewhere between a shrug and frustration.

“And anyway,” he said “If it’s just a nurse doing a bit of innocent moonlighting the police and the security service would blow it up out of proportion and she might lose both jobs”

Chapter Fourteen

They had got straight into the Mercedes as they had promised and been whisked off to Finn's house. They had the house to themselves all afternoon and had enjoyed some fun together. They'd laughed and joked while they made a family dinner but the rest of the evening was spent working. Adam had some catching up to do and Finn had received some new information from one of his three colleagues. A new potential project to discuss, plan out and most importantly estimate the price.

At 11pm Adam went to bed after a chaste goodnight kiss and Finn went back to his computer rig. The whole rigmarole was on wheels and Finn had moved it into the guest bedroom a couple of weeks before so he wouldn't disturb Adam.

He worked with his colleagues until 2am, snuggled up next to Adam to sleep but, when Adam woke up at 7am, Finn was gone.

A note on the bedside table just read

"Gone to scratch an itch and check a hunch. Love, Secret Squirrel"

Finn stood in the main hospital entrance, just across from the lifts. He looked totally anonymous, like any other teenager, which he nearly was, with a hood pulled up and obsessively scrolling on his phone. Scruffy jeans, woolly hat under his hood and dirty trainers made up the casual skater look that seemed harmless enough.

All night he hadn't been able to cast aside his weird feeling that he had stumbled on something significant. Every time he tried to logically think through scenarios there was a missing link that left them senseless and unlikely. Was this the missing link? Only one way to find out.

Finn was deliberately, and casually, leaning against a wall next to double doors marked 'Gynaecology Department – Outpatients Clinic'

in big letters. He felt confident that several passers-by would have laughed at the awkward teenage boy who really didn't want to go into gynaecology with his mother.

He waited patiently. He knew exactly what he was looking for but he had to wait nearly an hour before striking gold.

Walking towards the bank of lifts was Darren Carr. Finn didn't know him but he knew the type. Darren was in his late 20's or maybe 30 with long straggly hair tied back in a ponytail. He was wearing scruffy jeans and a camouflage jacket with lapel badges saying 'Peace', 'Stop Social Injustice' and a multi-sided shape like one of dice used in Dungeons and Dragons. He was carrying a desktop computer under one arm.

Harmless thought Finn uncharitably but probably works here where his limited technical knowledge will seem mystical to some.

For Finn the best part was that he could see a lanyard dangling from Darren's jacket pocket. A lanyard that Darren was too cool to wear around his neck but it proved his hospital ID.

Finn put his phone away and slouched over to the lifts, like a teenager too cool for his own good. The hospital was crowded and there were a lot of people waiting. There was the usual dance when the doors opened of letting people off but without giving up your place in the crowd.

Finn placed himself just behind Darren and as they all moved into the lift, there was some jostling. The lift was full and three people didn't get on. People called out numbers to the man closest to the bank of buttons and, as soon as Darren called out six, Finn called out eight.

It couldn't have worked out better for Finn. As he stepped out onto the Administration level on the eighth floor Finn undid the zip on his hoody and put his woolly hat in his pocket. Tucked into his jeans he pulled out a small clipboard and his phone and, once he looped the

lanyard and ID card over his head, he was suddenly Darren Carr from the IT department.

Finn smiled. He knew it was all a question of confidence. If you look like you belong... you belong.

He walked along the corridor with offices either side – some large and some individuals. Finn consulted the paper on his clipboard but kept his head swivelling from side to side. He had a very specific goal in mind.

At the end of the corridor he turned, looking a little confused. To one side of the corridor was a small alcove with a kettle, a coffee jug and some clean mugs. Finn quickly pressed the button on the kettle and put a fresh coffee filter into the other machine. He filled it with a fresh jug of water and watched as it started to drip though.

It's all about belonging.

He'd found his target but needed to get his approach right. On the way back he stopped outside an open door marked 'Neil Bevan – Deputy Head of Administration Services' and knocked gently.

"Mr Bevan?" he said with a smile "I'm from IT" Finn didn't bother showing his ID, just let it dangle visibly from his neck.

"We were told you were having trouble with your Internet connection so I've come to fix it"

"About time" grumbled Bevan "I complained weeks ago"

"I'm so sorry" Finn said smoothly "we're a bit snowed under at the moment"

Neil Bevan didn't look cared for. His shirt was rumpled and creased and there was a visible stain on his tie. He looked to have shaved badly this morning and he was on the wrong side of overweight. All in all Neil Bevan's appearance screamed divorce, crippled by child support and probably living in one room.

“It will probably only take me a few minutes but if you shut down anything confidential and leave me with the Internet I’ll just be a jiffy. I know it’s a pain when the Internet is like treacle” Finn was warm and sympathetic and could see Bevan starting to close down any financial information on his screen.

“Actually...” Finn gestured to the empty coffee cup on the desk “I noticed someone has just put fresh coffee on so if you want to grab a fresh cup I’ll be done by the time you get back”

Bevan picked up his coffee cup and gestured Finn into his seat. Finn was relying on the coffee machine being similar to his old job and it taking several minutes to filter through so Bevan would need to wait, probably pleased with the short break.

Watching the coffee pour through into the fresh pot Neil Bevan zoned out thinking about his amazing stroke of luck recently. He’d had a messy divorce and his ex-wife had, he imagined, turned his two teenage children against him. His wife had stayed in their house with the children but Neil suspected, even if the children went off to university, she would try to stay put.

He didn’t feel bitter. He was past that – a long way past that. No doubt his kids would come back one day – probably with their hands out. It had surprised Neil that, if he was brutally honest with himself, he just didn’t like his children much. He genuinely thought they had grown into selfish little monsters.

Was he to blame? Should he take the blame? He’d given up trying to understand that one a long time ago. The only thing he did know is that he should never have married his ex-wife. Marry in haste, repent at leisure they say and for Neil it was definitely true.

He’d spent the past eight years living in a crappy studio apartment, scrimping and saving to pay child support but also to put together a small nest egg for himself. Soon, he told himself, he could put down a deposit on a nice place of his own.

That thought made him smile, especially because he had recently met someone who he hoped would share it with him. How lucky he was after eight years on his own with barely a date, to suddenly meet the woman of his dreams. A woman that was a perfect fit for him... his soulmate.

As he sat down Finn knew he'd chosen wisely. Neil Bevan was a security nightmare because every system in the hospital that he needed to access, which pretty much everything, had a username and password written on a post-it note attached along the top of his monitor.

Aware of the time constraints Finn quickly pulled out his phone and took photos of all the post-its. Then, as belt and braces, he switched to HD video and slowly panned along the line again. Putting his phone away he pulled out a small USB drive and inserted it into the computer. He copied a small file deep in the folder structure and then opened a terminal window before tapping a few keys.

Less than two minutes gone and finally he opened a Web browser. He quickly deleted a huge amount of cached items, the browser history and some other crap. One thing made him frown but he would look at that later.

Less than four minutes and he was standing up to leave. In the corridor Neil Bevan was just pouring his coffee 30 feet away.

"All done" called Finn "It'll go like a rocket now but any problems give us a ring and ask for Darren."

Bevan waved begrudgingly but said nothing.

Back in the lift Finn put on his woolly hat, pulled up his hood and took off the ID. For the first two floors he was alone in the lift. "Keep cool" he told himself. He reached into his pocket and put on the obligatory surgical mask. Half the people in the hospital were wearing them after Covid.

On the ground floor Finn stopped at the reception desk.

“I found this by the lifts over there” he said, a smile in his voice and eyes even though most of his face was hidden. “I think it’s a hospital ID”

“Thank you” said the receptionist, taking it but barely looking up.

Back at home Adam was working on his thesis on the dining table when Finn arrived. They hugged and sat down for a cup of tea together but Finn was very guarded about his morning exploits.

“I need to do some research this afternoon and maybe this evening then all will be revealed.”

Adam had lots of his own work to do so decided to be patient.

In front of his screens Finn started to work. Neil Bevan wouldn’t notice the piggyback rider on his computer and for the main systems Finn was just accessing them directly anyway.

Finn accessed nursing shift records, personnel files and personal logins. Bevan’s login details took him more or less everywhere he wanted to go but some places called on his very specific skills.

All IT security is only as good as the weakest link and often that weak link was the idiot with his passwords written on post-it notes. No sense in hacking anything when you are invited in the front door.

As he worked Finn went from ‘What the fuck?’ to ‘Oh my God’ and back to “No, it can’t be’.

Finn stared at his screens. All the evidence in front of him. Undeniable.

He knew the answer. Finn knew why Adam was in danger and he needed to tell Adam, and his dad, as soon as possible.

Chapter Fifteen

Finn took a deep breath as he sat across the dining table from Adam and his parents.

“So... some laws were broken so I need you to be listening as my dad not a police officer.” he addressed Marc.

“I’m not even here Finn,” Marc said looking concerned.

“Can the laws that were broken be traced back to you?” Steven asked.

“Highly unlikely but it also means there’s nothing we could put up in court,” Finn countered.

“Let me worry about that” Marc said “what have you got?”

“OK, when we went to the hospital to see James, I saw something that was so off-kilter it made me suspicious. Actually, more like, it made me curious”

“And this was yesterday when we met Margaret Brand?” Marc asked.

“Yes, and today I was able to access the hospital’s systems...”

“How?” Marc interrupted.

Finn sighed. “I went to the hospital, stole an ID card and made an IT Support visit to a senior guy. He had a whole list of passwords written out on his monitor.”

Marc sighed but said nothing. Finn wasn’t sure if it was at him or the lack of decent system security. He decided it was him but... too late now.

Finn went on to outline the different systems he’s accessed and why.

“The first revelation is that our waitress called Nikki is actually a nurse called Holly Foreman. I wasn’t sure which was the genuine person but I tracked down a death certificate for a Nikki Bartlett years ago.”

He looked at his dad with a half-smile “Public domain info Dad”

“So, Holly Foreman is a qualified nurse, she lives in South London in a bedsit, no family that I could find initially. It just seemed so odd that a nurse would moonlight as a waitress when agency work was a lot better paid.”

“She must have had a reason for working in the cafe then,” Adam said.

“Indeed and I think it was because she was stalking a regular there and wanted to get closer.”

“That doesn’t sound good” Adam said quietly “Is it me?”

“Yes Adam, but wait till we get on to the why” Finn replied.

“According to her personnel file...” Finn continued “she’s had a fairly unblemished, if unspectacular, record in the last few years at this hospital but in the past month she’s been involved in three incidents of carelessness and received a formal written warning.”

“So something is changing” Steven said.

“Judging by some of her supervisors' written reports it looks like she’s falling apart. My guess is that the written reports are fairly watered down in case she’s just going through a bad patch but overall... I think she’s unravelling.”

“And the timescale fits with the attacks on Adam?” Marc had a detective’s nose for a timeline.

“More or less. It’s like the first failure didn’t affect her much but then it went downhill from there. Perhaps it’s important to say that she didn’t show up for work today. Completely out of character.”

Finn looked down at the brief notes on the piece of paper in front of him. "I've got a load of stuff ready to print off upstairs but I just needed to get this to you quickly."

"By logging in to Holly's personal account at the hospital I could see all her activity on that system. Everything is dull and humdrum - timesheets, queries to payroll... normal crap. But she also used her work email to confirm she had sent a DNA sample in to one of these ancestry type websites that tell you if you're a sixteenth French or had Viking ancestors"

Finn paused for breath and took in the faces opposite him. They were all frowning wondering where this was going.

"One thing stands out from her hospital login though. Nearly a year ago she accessed archived details of an old Clinical Trial held at the hospital in the early 2000's. It was a scientific study on DNA Testing for Alcoholism Tendency using either current or recovering alcoholics. They were trying to establish whether there's a genetic link to alcohol abuse via DNA testing"

He looked at Adam "Bad news Adam, there's about a 50% genetic risk for developing alcohol dependence so I will need to keep an eye on you for the rest of your life."

Finn smiled at Adam who could only muster a weak smile in return.

"This is where it gets a little bit technical. DNA is measured in centimorgans..."

"What's a centimorgan?" Marc asked.

"To be honest I have no idea and I didn't want to waste time down that particular rabbit-hole," Finn replied. "All I know is that we each have 7400 of them give or take and we get half from each parent. So, a child shares roughly 3700 centimorgans with each parent and siblings share 1600 to 3500. Half-siblings share about 1,200 to 2,400"

“Well if I never hear the word centimorgan again I’ll be happy” said Marc.

Finn went on “I compared her DNA sample she’d got someone at the hospital to do, with the sample she’d found in the scientific study and, last year, Holly found out who her biological father was”

Adam looked directly at Finn. You could see the wheels spinning as he came to a realisation.

“and...?”

“Adam... her father is your father. Holly is your half sister”

Chapter Sixteen

“Jesus...” exclaimed Steven “that’s amazing.”

Adam just stared at Finn open mouthed. “Your dad was in hospital getting dried out again and agreed to give a DNA sample as part of the trial. As far as I can tell Holly pieced together enough information about her parentage and might have even got a job at the hospital to access medical records but either way, it’s pretty conclusive.”

“My dad often got dried out or went to rehab or had counselling but to be honest he never really wanted to quit. He would have handed round a bottle of scotch at an Alcoholics Anonymous meeting.” Adam spoke softly.

“I just don’t understand why she’d want to harm you though” Steven said

“Money” Adam and Marc both spoke at the same time.

“My grandmother’s will was rock-solid because my dad had already died. I inherited by name, not by some vague term like grandchild. Even with my will, if I died, she could probably contest the original will as the sole remaining blood relative of my grandmother. I don’t know enough about the law to be sure but...” Adam tailed off.

“It’s certainly a hell of a motive and will be an important part of the investigation into James’ stabbing. I’ll get on the phone straight away and also tell Scary Margaret the news.”

Finn looked at his dad and grimaced.

“There’s... something else” he said, sounding sheepish.

“Well it can’t be worse” Marc said.

“Not worse but... morally and ethically I think I did the right thing. Legally... not so much”.

Marc took a deep breath and let it out slowly. "Go on, how bad is it?"

"The guy I visited in the hospital seems to run most of his life off his work computer so, with complete access, I noticed a series of messages he'd exchanged with someone he'd met online. To be honest it absolutely screamed at me so I wanted to investigate... in and around all this other stuff"

No response around the table so Finn continued.

"Neil, the guy, has been catfished and is probably heading towards blackmail and sextortion."

Marc narrowed his eyes "And you did what?"

"Well, Neil met a woman online called Olena who claimed she was from Ukraine. She's an absolute looker but stuck there because of the war with her 12 year old son and her mother. She's terrified that there are attacks every night and civilians seem to be targeted. Her apartment block has been hit by rockets and her mother had to move in because her home was destroyed."

"But she's not what she seems?" Adam asked.

"Far from it. I traced the IP address on her computer. There was a bit of an attempt to camouflage it but nothing spectacular. I tracked it back to a middle aged gentleman in Lagos, Nigeria. Here's the good part though, I managed to fire up his laptop webcam and record him exchanging messages as Olena with someone in Australia. He, or she, was asking for money to escape."

"So it's a scam." said Marc. "but somehow I get the impression there's more"

Finn grimaced again "When I connected to his laptop I could see his bank details, in London ironically, and a list of other people he's scammed so... I might have logged on to his bank and cleared his account"

"Finn for fuck's sake"

“Don’t worry, I transferred all the money through accounts in the Dominican Republic and Cambodia, who don’t report banking transactions. Then I sent an anonymous email to Neil with screenshots, a video and an explanation that he’d been scammed. I also put £12,000 back in his bank account.”

“It’s like living with an electronic Robin Hood” said Steven with a laugh.

“I am only glad I wasn’t at home tonight to hear any of this” Marc said.

“I did the same thing to seven other people, all the money, and then I went back and told the guy I would be watching him and I’d returned all his money to his victims. Then I trashed the guy’s laptop”

“Good God, I hope I never upset you” said Marc.

Adam reached across the table and took Finn’s hand.

“Detective work obviously runs in your family. It’s like a new Inspector Griffin mystery for the 21st century. *You* are the new Inspector Griffin!” He smiled at Finn.

Adam felt more confident. It was like the ‘why’ had been filled in. Suddenly the pieces fitted together logically. Suddenly the unknown was known and didn’t seem as scary any more.

As they spoke, less than a mile across the river, Billy Fish checked the camera monitor when the bell rang.

He sighed “Not you again”

He went out to the door instead of buzzing it open.

“Yes?” he demanded

Holly stared back at him “I heard you can supply anything,” she said.

Billy looked ‘Nikki’ the waitress up and down. He was a good judge of character and his first instincts were rarely wrong. His sense was

that this was a highly strung person getting more stressed by the minute. He wasn't wrong.

"I don't *supply* anything but, for a small fee, I can put you in touch with a person that can supply almost anything you want".

Drugs? He thought to himself. Anybody could find their local friendly dealer by asking a couple of questions in their local pub. Fake documents? Get rid of stolen goods? Buy a stolen iPhone?

If he ignored the slight twitching and the agitation Billy would have put her down as an Air Fryer customer rather than anything illegal.

"I want to buy a gun" Holly said flatly.

Chapter Seventeen

Neil Bevan arrived at work, poured himself some coffee and sat down at his desk with a grunt. He'd heard nothing from his girlfriend Olena in Ukraine and he was concerned about overnight news reports about drone attacks on cities and residential buildings.

He checked his phone for any private messages and frowned again.

As soon as his computer finished booting up he silently cursed the IT Department who had, apparently, done nothing worthwhile during their recent visit. He double clicked on the Email icon hoping for at least something from Olena.

He scanned down the list of unread mail before blinking several times at one line.

'Open this first Neil. It's about Olena and important'

He might not be the most tech-savvy person in the world but he knew enough about scammers and phishers to be wary but, inevitably, curiosity won him over. He double clicked the title.

Hi Neil

This is a message from a friend but it contains some bad news and good news. I'm sorry to tell you that you have been scammed. The person you know as Olena does NOT exist. Look at the image below, this is the man pretending to be Olena. He is based in Lagos, Nigeria and has never left the country, let alone visited Ukraine.

As Neil scrolled down an embedded image of an overweight man appeared, apparently taken from his own webcam.

The next image shows a split screen with the man typing and a screenshot of his messages. You can see that he is trying to persuade someone else that he is Olena and just needs some help to get out of a war-torn country.

The next image in the email showed just that.

*Attached to this email is a video file with a lot more proof, including this man laughing with his friend that he has caught another one. You are not alone Neil - we have found another seven victims, all of whom have been scammed into helping 'Olena' financially, to a lesser or greater degree. After reviewing all this information, you can keep it or delete it but I **very strongly insist** that you never attempt to contact this man again.*

Neil let out a long breath that he hadn't realised he'd been holding in. His first thought was of Olena and the sense of betrayal but shortly after he thought of the money he'd sent.

I said there was good news too. I have returned £12,000 to your bank account. The money was taken from this gentleman but there is no way to trace the payment back from him. I have done the same thing with all the other victims and sent a similar email.

I know this is a terrible shock Neil. I know you'll be upset and angry, but you need to move on. Accept that it happened and be glad it turned out well. Life gets better.

*I will never contact you again Neil and there is no need for thanks or any type of reward. All I ask is two things. Firstly, I want you to spend the morning going through your phone and your computer and change every single password you have to something more secure - even that account on Pornhub that you don't often use. Both work and personal passwords. Most importantly, I want you to learn this lesson well. There are unscrupulous people out there who will bleed you dry with a smile on their face. They **always** have a convincing story.*

Good luck Neil, and stay vigilant

A Friend

Neil stared at the message, not reading, barely comprehending. Olena doesn't exist, was his initial thought and he scrolled through some photos on his phone. It seemed so real, so perfect. She had said wonderful things to him, they had planned a future, they were happy.

His eyes stared to mist but then a second thought hit him. He quickly pulled up his banking app and there, without any doubt, was a credit of £12,000.

He felt angry and more than a little ashamed. He felt like he'd been duped because he had been stupid, stupid and desperate. "Life gets better?" he snorted out loud "well it couldn't get worse could it?"

As he sat at his desk, staring at the message again, a thought formed in his head. He had been cheated by a wicked, shameless person but someone kind and moral had stepped in and helped him. His best response now would be to do as he had been asked - change all his passwords and be hyper-aware of more scammers in the future.

Neil minimised his email window and pulled up the first work system. As he logged in he took down the post-it note from his monitor and stuck it to the desk next to his keyboard.

He reached into his desk drawer and pulled out a small notebook. He opened a blank page and carefully wrote down his username and new password because some things don't change quickly.

The Lucerne Hotel in Westminster was an institution. It was quiet, refined and discreet. Just off the main door, but after running the watchful eye of the doorman and reception desk, Chester's Bar was small but secluded. It was the sort of place where politicians or titans of industry could hack out a deal - as long as they were considerate and tactful. It was somewhere the King and Queen could go for a quiet drink and everybody, staff and customers, would act as if it were a normal occurrence, and quietly ignore them.

The Lucerne was also reassuringly expensive.

Holly was surprised and a little overawed at the venue. When Billy Fish gave her the name and number of a gun dealer, she expected a seedy back alley and the back of a car. This was something else.

You didn't need to know anything about Jonny Mason to know he was rich and privileged. Everything from his clothes to his haircut spoke of his upbringing, his incredibly expensive education and his sense of style.

Mason had left school for the Royal Military Academy Sandhurst with a glittering military career beckoning. Awarded the Sword of Honour at the passing out parade Jonny was considered the best of his class. He went straight to a prestigious regiment.

After tours in Iraq and Afghanistan Jonny was suspected of selling off weapons. There was no hard evidence but there was probably enough to stain his career forever. Given the choice of resignation or a Court Martial, Jonny left the army.

He numbered Princes, Aristocrats, Politicians and people with real influence among his friends but he also had some very low-life acquaintances too.

As he watched Holly cross the thick carpet towards him he raised an eyebrow. He really will have to have a hard word with Billy Fish. Jonny dealt in quantity as well as quality. He wasn't interested in little deals and certainly not to civilians. The woman walking towards him looked like she was stressfully juggling three kids and a supermarket job.

Holly had made an effort but she knew she stood out. Get it over with, she told herself. She was definitely intimidated.

Jonny stood and smiled as she approached. He was urbane and sophisticated, the crease in his Saville Row trousers was razor sharp, as was his mind. He gestured Holly to a seat opposite him and discreetly waved the hovering waiter away.

"Well this is... unusual" he said with a thin smile.

“Billy Fish told me to call you because I have a problem with my ex. He’s already been in prison for violent controlling and coercive behaviour but he’s out now and is already banging on my door at 3am. He’s not supposed to come near me but the police won’t do anything... until he kills me probably.”

“and you want... what from me?” Jonny was analysing, calculating the odds. The potential trouble versus a quick hit.

“I just want something to threaten him with. Something to wave around and scare him off” Holly whispered “something to scare him off forever”.

Jonny Mason was a lot of things. He was cold-hearted, unemotional, manipulative and shrewd but he hated to see women abused by bullies. Call him old-fashioned but Jonny Mason was a gentleman.

“OK,” he said slowly and quietly “this is a one-off situation that never happened. A Glock 17 handgun is one of the most popular handguns in the world. It is literally point and shoot but it has no safety catch so be sure when you handle it. It’s a thousand pounds cash”

Holly reached for her bag.

“No, no no...” Jonny smiled, holding up his hand “you go out of the main door, turn left and you’ll see a black Mercedes parked by the kerb. Give the money to the driver, Alan, and he will deliver the package.”

He pulled out his phone as a gesture of dismissal and started dialling without a goodbye.

Outside Holly took a deep breath. *Almost there* she thought.

She could see the Mercedes to her left. The engine was running as she walked up to it. From the passenger side she ducked down to talk to the driver, who was just putting his phone away.

“Alan?” she asked.

“Don’t poke your head in like that. You look like a bloody hooker. Come round to this side” Alan, whose name was actually Paul, gestured her round to the front of the car.

As she got to the open driver’s window,, Alan said “Stand up straight and look down at my lap. I’ll show you the item.”

Holly looked down and Alan had a handgun in his lap. It looked dark, metallic and threatening.

“This is important so pay attention. It’s a Glock 17, fully loaded, ready to go. When you’re ready for action you pull back this top section and let it go” Alan mimed the action of pulling back the slide and releasing it.

Holly had an odd moment when she thought it was like a Flight Attendant pointing out emergency exits but she paid careful attention.

“Now... pay attention. There is no safety so, if you pull back the slide, there is a round ready to go. Keep your finger off the trigger until you really intend to fire. It’s a hair trigger so it doesn’t take much. OK? Do you understand all that?

Holly nodded.

“Cash” said Alan.

She handed over an envelope, which Alan didn’t open. He put the handgun into a simple supermarket bag. Handed it over and put the car into drive.

“Mind your toes,” he said but drove off before she’d even moved.

Meanwhile Jonny had left the hotel through another entrance. As he walked along the street he was talking to Billy Fish.

“If you do that to me again Billy, we will fall out”

“I know Jonny, “ Billy said smoothly “but she seems like a good kid and, if I’d have sent her south of the river they would probably have

taken her money and shot her in the head just for asking.”

“You owe me Billy,” Jonny said, hanging up.

Billy wasn't too bothered. He owed lots of people and lots of people owed him. It all went around and had given him a good living.

Holly walked along the road with her surprisingly heavy shopping bag. She had a Glock 17 and she knew how to use it. Another item ticked off her list.

What Holly didn't know was that she didn't have a Glock 17. She had a Vietnamese knock-off - an SN19, a close replica made in the Z111 factory in Thanh Hóa in northern Vietnam. An expert would know instantly but an amateur like Holly would not.

If she'd have known Jonny was just clearing out some old stock she still wouldn't have cared. As long as it did the job - it's only got to work once she would have told herself.

Chapter Eighteen

Floral Street in London runs parallel to Covent Garden and is within the pedestrianised zone. Usually full of people, delivery drivers need to move slowly. The cobbled street and the heavy metal bollards ensure slow movement, even for the few vehicles that are allowed.

Holly had spent hours poring over online maps, satellite images and Google Street View. She'd walked down Floral Street many times in the past but now, as she walked slowly along, she was suddenly noticing more things. Were they significant? She didn't know, but she felt comforted that she was noticing them.

She walked up and down the street four or five times, apparently enjoying the happy atmosphere of people on holiday in the capital or local office workers on a night out.

Holly stopped and looked at a shoe shop. Cheap shoes, but at inflated prices because of the location. In reality, Holly was studying the black painted door to the side of the shop. There were four entryphone buttons on a panel but no names listed.

The lock on the main door was simple. Her skills were more than a match.

She crossed back to the other side of the narrow street and idly looked up, as if enjoying the architecture.

"No lights" she whispered to herself. The third night running there were no visible lights in the whole of the upper building. *Probably all owned by some Oligarch hiding his money*, she thought. *Tomorrow, tomorrow will work* and she smiled.

She walked away, east towards Drury Lane, deliberately avoiding the Piazza at Covent Garden and turning south to cross Waterloo Bridge. She made sure to avoid any area like the cafe where she

might bump into someone who knew her. With her hood pulled up she was confident she was just another nobody in London.

After walking across the bridge she turned right along the embankment towards the London Eye. The sight of her previous failure rankled a little but she was so confident in her new plan she shook it off. She arrived at the Amazon lockers and retrieved her order.

At her side the handgun clonked against body. It was securely zipped into an inside pocket of her quilted jacket. In truth, the gun terrified her but she didn't feel comfortable hiding it in her room. She didn't feel comfortable carrying it either so zipping it up seemed like a good alternative. It wasn't as if she was likely to need a quick draw.

Holly made her way back to her drab little room to work on her new purchases. She thought she'd been clever, using her Nikki identity to create space between her and any purchases. Nikki had been diligent in keeping up her credit card payments for years.

"Not much longer now" she told herself "Then who will be the failure?"

"You will be. You *a/ways* will be" It was her mother's voice coming deep down from Holly's mind.

"Not this time Mother, you'll see" she replied

Adam had moved into Finn's house and, despite the worry over Holly, he'd really enjoyed the family life. Marc and Steven made him feel welcome and he realised he was expected to conform to the normal standards Finn had to. Always checking in with Marc or Steven was especially important at the moment. Adam found that his name had been added to the timetable for chores and meal preparation. He thought that was strangely comforting.

When he reviewed the events of the past few weeks, he was surprised at how much life had changed. He'd met a new partner and had great hopes of a long term relationship. Early days, he kept

telling himself but deep down he really wanted it to work and he thought Finn felt the same way.

Perhaps more of a shock was that he had a sister, a half-sister more correctly. He'd always grown up accepting that he was an only child. He didn't feel positive or negative about that, it was just a fact. He wondered what it would have been like growing up with an older sister. Somewhere between good fun and awful - probably no different to what any sibling relationship would be like he thought.

Finn seemed to have a good relationship with his Mum and sister, although Adam hadn't met them yet. *Maybe sisters weren't all psychos.* Adam laughed to himself.

It had been 4 days since they worked out who Holly was. Marc had passed on information to the detectives investigating James' stabbing and had received some unofficial feedback. The police knew that Holly hadn't been at the hospital or the cafe since the day after the stabbing. They had also discovered that the home address on record in both places was a room Holly had moved out of over a year ago.

Whether it was intuition or blind luck, Holly had gone to ground.

Marc had taken a phone call from Margaret Brand who told him that she was trying to twist a few arms to get the security services to use facial recognition on the streets. The terse response had been that it was not a matter of national security. Marc got the feeling that Margaret Brand had noted down who was making those decisions and, not for the first time, he was glad he was on the right side.

Everybody said it was only a question of time before they apprehended Holly. Adam and Finn had privately discussed that they should just be cautious and aware until they knew more. Fortunately Adam had a lot of work to do on his final thesis so they were rarely outside the house.

One bright point was a photo from a very happy looking James captioned 'On my way HOME!'. They had replied with a promise to

go and visit him, or maybe to go for dinner as a foursome.

It was Adam's thesis that was giving him a headache at the moment. Finn had worked through the night last night on a major project and had finally crashed at about five in the afternoon. Adam had been struggling all day because he was unable to find some of the data he'd collated earlier. He searched his laptop and the cloud storage service he used but it was nowhere to be found.

It was nearly 8pm when he realised it was on a USB drive sitting on his desk in Covent Garden. He went upstairs and looked in at Finn, asleep but still looking wrecked.

He made an instant, impulsive decision. Ring for a car, make him wait while he went up to the flat, back out in 5 minutes and on his way back. At least he wasn't walking, he'd be safe in the car.

He left a note for Finn, although he was confident he'd be back before Finn surfaced or Marc and Steven got in late from work.

He called for a car and watched from the window as it pulled up ten minutes later. Adam didn't really know the driver but he'd definitely seen him before. It occurred to him that he should maybe have asked for a driver he knew better.

On the short journey his phone rang and the display showed the name of the shop on the ground floor of his building.

"Mr Griffin? I'm sorry to call you but this is Vivienne Bridger, I'm the manager of the store below you"

"How did you get this number?" Adam asked.

"Errr... it was just in the desk drawer here. Should I not have called?"

Adam said nothing so she continued.

"I have been trying to contact the building maintenance company all afternoon because there is a line of water running down the fire

escape stairs. I can't tell where it's coming from but I really need to close up and leave now."

"And you tried the maintenance people?" Adam said.

"Yes, I'm out of ideas now and I didn't want to just ignore it, but I really have to leave now"

"Don't worry. I'm five minutes away. I'll get on to it."

Thank you so much, normally I could stay but I really can't tonight"

They exchanged farewells and, as he hung up, Adam felt a tingling at the back of his neck.

In Covent Garden, overlooking the Piazza, Holly clicked her phone off. She pulled out the SIM and snapped it. It had been a good plan to set up a mobile phone to appear to be the store downstairs and it had worked. She watched Vivienne walk across the Piazza heading home 5 minutes earlier. Why would anyone assume it wasn't Vivienne on the phone?

She waited patiently, in the dark.

Earlier that evening, just as the day descended into twilight, Holly walked confidently along Floral Street until she stopped outside the black painted door next to the shoe shop. She wore black jeans, black lightweight running shoes and a black hoody with a loose, high-visibility jacket on top emblazoned across the back with one word. LOCKSMITH - in 3" high letters. Her purchase from Amazon.

Without realising it she had come to the same conclusion as Finn. If you look like you belong and you look confident, nobody will bother you.

She crouched in front of the door putting her small black rucksack in front of her. People were passing by within a couple of feet of her but nobody noticed her. She went to work on the lock and impressed herself with the speed she worked it open.

As the door opened she stepped inside, listening intently inside and out. Nothing. No bleeping of an alarm inside and no sound of concern outside.

She shut the door, still listening. Her own breath sounded loud and raspy in the small lobby. She took a moment to control herself and her breathing.

When she was calmer, she stripped off the high-vis jacket - it had done its job - and she pulled a small head-torch out of her rucksack.

It lit up the stairs ahead of her and she silently started to climb upwards. This was the only unknown part of her plan. So far so good, she made it to the top floor.

She hadn't known if the exit would be in the top floor flat or the landing. It was on the landing and Holly smiled. *One less lock to pick*, she thought.

The door ahead of her was just bolted on the inside, no lock at all, and almost instantly Holly stepped out onto a small flat roof. From her study of the satellite images online she had assumed it was access for some sort of maintenance.

More importantly for Holly, she now stood on the only structure at the same level as her target - Adam's roof garden. Every other surrounding building was either a 15 foot vertical climb or a 15 foot drop to get to his building. All the other options were too risky.

Despite how easy it looked on the satellite images Holly soon realised that she had to walk along narrow ledges that were 50 feet in the air above a dark alley and glass skylights of lower buildings.

She put on her rucksack, taking comfort from the scary weight of the gun it contained, and started to walk.

She muttered encouragement to herself quietly as she negotiated parapets, chimney stacks and low walls as she moved from building to building. Getting closer.

Finally she had one last obstacle. About twenty feet of sloping roof before she made it to the roof garden. She climbed into position slowly. The pitched roof that had seemed manageable online now felt steep, slippery and unsafe.

Holly moved forward slowly. She could feel gravity pulling her downwards. She wasn't sure whether to go slowly or make a dash for it. There was nothing to hold on to. The roof tiles felt crumbly and ancient and Holly realised she was getting spooked.

Her shoes had no grip. Her hands, covered in latex gloves, felt numb and unresponsive. She could feel her palms sweating inside her gloves.

She edged forward, subconsciously choosing the slow steady approach. She felt her feet slipping on some moss on the tiles but suddenly she had a handhold. An edge. The edge. The edge of the roof that dropped into Adam's terrace.

With a final heave and a roll, she made it. Safe.

She turned her head-torch back on to locate the doors. A pitiful lock she thought and within seconds she was inside.

Inside Adam Griffin's apartment. The apartment that should have been hers. Her birthright. She had waited so long.

It was now completely dark and the torch picked out a desk and comfortable chair. She saw the stairs down and made her way down into the main floor. Her second visit.

Holly had decided there was no way she was going to make the return journey across the rooftops, even before she'd realised how daunting it was in reality, so she started her plan.

She looked around the main room and decided where she would wait. She considered angles and possibilities and then planned where she would make Adam sit and where she could safely stand over him.

Once she had decided all this, she went to the fire escape. She went down the four flights, despite the lights, and sneaked a look into the shop. Vivienne seemed engrossed with a rich looking Chinese woman who was picking up bags and just dropping them. Her face was a mask of polite deference but Holly could almost feel Vivienne's irritation. It was nearly closing time and the woman just waved her arm dismissively and headed for the door.

Holly slid back the new bolt on the outside door. She had been right about the bolts. Then she opened the door a fraction, just enough to slide her wedge in. It was enough to ensure a quick exit and no chance of the panic bar jamming. From the outside it would take a close inspection to see it wasn't locked tight.

Back upstairs, she did the same to the apartment door and then she was ready.

Unlike before, if Adam came home with his boyfriend, she would take care of them both. The gun would even out the odds.

She made a phone call. Then she waited patiently, in the dark.

Chapter Nineteen

There was something about the phone call that made Adam uneasy. Something that wouldn't form in his mind. It seemed unlikely that he would have given his number to anyone in the shop but just possible the building maintenance people had. It wasn't that.

It wasn't that the building maintenance company wasn't answering. There could be a logical reason for that especially now it was out of hours. Maybe the store manager was just covering her backside so she could at least say she'd told *someone*.

And yet... something was wrong.

Adam cursed himself because he knew there was a business card for the maintenance company next to his keyboard upstairs and he'd been meaning to save the numbers to his phone.

In the lift up to his apartment he decided to call Finn. Partly to apologise for leaving the house unannounced and partly to put his mind at rest. He'd be back there in ten or fifteen minutes but he just wanted to hear Finn's voice.

The phone rang several times and Adam imagined Finn groggily scrambling for his phone.

As he opened his front door Adam instinctively sniffed the air. Now he knew something was definitely wrong. He rolled his thumb across the volume switch on his phone just as he saw Finn answer. Finn could hear but Adam's phone was silent.

"Hello Holly," he said, flicking on every light in the flat from the front door. "I wondered when you'd turn up at my apartment".

Finn jumped at the words from his phone, instantly transformed from half asleep and dozey to wide awake and alert. It was like he'd had a caffeine injection straight into his bloodstream.

“Adam? Where are you?” he shouted. Immediately he realised Adam couldn't hear him and why.

“Clever” he said out loud and set his phone to record the one-sided conversation.

Then he jumped up and ran downstairs hoping his dad was at home.

“Sit there,” Holly said, using the pistol to indicate the large sofa.

Adam sat where she pointed.

“I'm surprised we haven't met before to be honest,” Adam said. He looked the image of cool composure and relaxation. As if he faced crazy gun wielding people every day. Inside his head there was screaming and recriminations. How could he be so stupid? So reckless? Why hadn't he woken up Finn so they could have come together.

The thought of Finn made something click in his brain. Holly could have shot him in the doorway. She didn't so, logically, she wanted to talk but she would have nothing to talk to Finn about. If Adam had brought Finn, Finn would already be dead.

The thought of Finn alive, surviving, filled Adam with a sense of calm. The fear lessened. It didn't leave him but it wasn't overwhelming him.

“So you know I'm Holly not Nikki?” Holly seemed calm and in control “what else do you know?”

“I know you're my sister... well, same father”

“The father who abandoned us!” Holly shouted, suddenly sounding a little less in control.

“Did he? That doesn't really sound like him.”

“Yes he did and I had a terrible childhood because of him. He was a monster who left my mother when she was pregnant and never came back”

“Did he know your mother was pregnant?”

It was a simple question but it hit Holly like a speeding bus. She almost staggered physically. It was the one question she had never asked. In all of her mothers drunken rants, in all of the recrimination and woe Holly couldn't remember her mother saying that her father knew she was pregnant. Not once.

Adam knew nothing about guns but he'd heard of weapons with hair triggers and he didn't like the way Holly's finger was on the trigger and how she was flexing her hand, no doubt sweating in her latex glove.

“Do you wear gloves all the time?” he asked as a distraction.

“What?” Holly sounded momentarily confused.

“I know you wear them in the cafe and presumably at the hospital but overuse can make your hands smell funny.” Adam smiled. “It's how I knew you were here just now. I recognised the smell of the latex gloves and the alcohol based hand sanitiser. There's none at the café so, when I found out about the hospital, it all made sense.”

“You think you're so clever” Holly sneered “you with your perfect childhood. You didn't have to cope with an alcoholic, bi-polar, mother. No money and a shitty home. I had secondhand clothes until I was a working adult. Even my underwear!!” Holly raised her voice and there was a slight crack in her speech.

“If your mother was an alcoholic you'll know that I didn't have a perfect childhood. OK it might have been better than yours because I was protected by my Grandma from the worst of his drinking, but still... it often got ugly”

“It's not the same,” said Holly. “If he hadn't abandoned us, if he hadn't just walked away, my life would have been better. If he'd just acknowledged us, helped with money... God knows he had enough”

“That's what doesn't make sense Holly. My dad...*our* dad, was a useless drunk. He was unreliable. He was feckless and

untrustworthy and all the bad things you'd expect. But, ahead of all those things and without the drink, he was warm and kind and caring. There is absolutely no way he would have abandoned you if he had known about you"

Adam could see tears forming in Holly's eyes. He didn't know if it was sorrow, frustration or anger.

"He would have loved you Holly. He would have cared for you".

Tears openly rolled down Holly's cheeks now. Holding the gun up, pointing at Adam, was making her arm tremble slightly.

Holly was trying to process this information. In her head her mother was screaming 'Abandoned, he abandoned us' over and over. Had her mother lied? Had he just left her because of her addictions and huge mood swings?

"NO!" she shouted "No, he left us to rot. He left me to be the laughing stock at school for my old lady knickers from dead people... from the charity shop. He left me to be a carer for that stupid, fucking drunk when I was the one who needed looking after."

"My grandmother would have loved you too," Adam said softly. He wasn't sure where he was going with this but he wanted to keep going. He felt every moment's delay was important.

Holly stared open mouthed at him. She had always thought of her father's mother as a sort of cash cow, never as a source of love and affection.

"She was my best friend" Adam sounded like he was speaking to himself "and I was hers but I always sensed she would be happy with more grandchildren - especially a girl. And if my dad didn't do the right thing, she would have."

"He'd have kept his grubby little secret from her"

Adam laughed "It's a shame you didn't know her. He couldn't keep anything from her. Drunk or sober he couldn't resist. She had a

sharp mind and a scary memory. Nobody outwitted her.”

Holly sighed “You'd say anything now” she waved the gun at him “because of this. But I knew I needed a better plan”

“What was the plan, out of interest?” Adam asked. “Were you planning to kill me and then pitch up at the bank asking for a debit card?”

“I'm not stupid you know. Initially I thought I could push you under the train and wait a few months before revealing that I was the true heir to Elspeth Potter.”

“Very dramatic but unlikely,” Adam couldn't resist a dose of common sense.

“Then the van. It's amazing what you can learn from the Internet. I learnt how to hotwire a car but I chose a 45 year old Ford Transit because it didn't have a steering lock and the wiring was more accessible. Thank you, Internet!”

“But now? Are you just going to shoot me like a burglary gone wrong and hope some lawyer tracks you down?”

“Better than that. When you're dead I'm going to take a DNA sample from your cheek.” She pulled a sample tube from her pocket and waved it triumphantly. “Then I'm going to post it with an application form to the same DNA ancestry site I used a few months ago. They'll process it and in a few weeks I'll receive a notification that I have a half brother. Sadly, a half brother who died on the day he posted his test to them.”

“Then what?” Adam was losing patience, forgetting about the gun momentarily.

“I inherit as I was supposed to because I'm your closest relative”

“What about my will?” Adam asked.

Holly looked confused, off balance. She hadn't really considered that a healthy twenty one year old would have made a will. It was something old people do.

"Do you seriously think, with all this money, all this responsibility and the best legal advice, I wouldn't make a will?"

"I'd contest the will" Holly said but suddenly not feeling confident. She started to shift her weight from foot to foot nervously. What was happening? She had all the cards. She had the gun.

"Just like I always said. You're useless. Completely stupid," her mother hissed in her ear.

Adam was angry. Not because she was going to shoot him but because it was all so pointless.

"Do you know what is so *stupid* about all this? he asked.

Holly said nothing but rocked on her feet.

"Your mother had enough information to track down our father and *Iguarantee* he would have looked after you both. After he died you could have contacted our grandmother and she would have welcomed you with open arms, including a big share of her will"

Holly moved her mouth but no words came out.

"Even if you'd have come to me after she died I would have shared her fortune with you. Do you know why? Because my grandmother and even my stupid alcoholic dad were decent, honourable people who believed in kindness and doing the right thing. And more than that, they raised me the same way."

Adam could see Holly's head starting to shake from side to side.

"NO, NO, NO" she screamed "we were abandoned, thrown away, made to feel worthless."

"Not by my family" Adam said firmly "you and your mother did this to yourself. It's so stupid!"

“I AM NOT STUPID” Holly screamed.

Chapter Twenty

Marc was just in from work, a late finish but he didn't mind because Steven was on a night shift. He opened his laptop on the dining table and opened his messaging app linked to his phone. He had a message from Billy Fish.

Finn ran downstairs three at a time. The noise made his dad spin round.

"Dad, Adam is in trouble... what the fuck is *that*? Finn exclaimed. He pointed to the laptop screen.

Marc looked back at a CCTV image of Holly on his screen. He read the message below. "Shit! It's from a snitch. Holly is trying to buy a gun" he told Finn.

"I think she already has, and she's inside Adam's apartment... with Adam."

Finn quickly outlined what he knew and what he suspected.

"We can run, it'll be quicker than waiting for a police car"

As they left the front door they heard the familiar sound of a big motorbike pulling up.

"Hello, I forgot my lunch box," said Steven cheerfully. Then his mood changed instantly when he sensed trouble. "What happened?"

They told him briefly and he just looked at Marc "Get on" he said gesturing with his head to the storage box behind him.

Paramedic bikes are designed for one person and a lot of equipment. Marc started to climb up onto a storage box that made him head and shoulders above Steven.

"If you two think you're leaving me behind you should know I'll never forgive you" Finn said.

“Don't be daft” Steven said “you're on the fuel tank” and he leant back into Marc to give Finn space to cock his leg over and settle between him and the windscreen.

“Sirens and lights till we're close” Marc said as Steven used incredible strength to level the bike and set off. With sirens wailing and lights flashing they cut through the evening traffic. It was exceptionally dangerous with only one of them in a helmet and Finn's neck resting on the windshield. *A sudden stop and it'll cut my head off* he thought.

Pedestrians and drivers watched them pass looking for all the world like a hideous stereotype of a South East Asian family going to market.

Finn could hear his dad shouting instructions into his mobile phone. He was relieved to hear him shouting A.R.V. In London there are Armed Response Vehicles roaming the streets at all times. They pride themselves in being able to reach any part of the sprawling capital in minutes.

It was less than two minutes when they pulled up by the Piazza. They had turned off the siren, then the lights so they didn't advertise and they immediately dismounted as Steven kicked down the stand. Finn, in his haste, fell off the bike and sat on the road. Jumping up, he looked up.

“There are lights on,” he said to himself. He closed his eyes, visualising the interior “can't use the lift, no key but too noisy anyway. The shop has access to the fire escape but is all locked up... the fire escape!”

Finn ran off to check the side door.

Marc and Steven were both surveying the scene professionally. Marc was an Authorised Firearms Officer but they didn't routinely carry weapons.

“When we work out access, I'll go in first followed by you. We'll spread out inside.” Steven spoke quietly and urgently. “You know there's no way Finn will wait down here don't you?”

Marc nodded grimly but before he could reply a white unmarked BMW glided silently to a halt. Four men were inside and all but the driver started to get out.

Police Sergeant Tony Scott walked towards them.

“Evening gentlemen.” He was calm and measured. “Can I just tell you that whatever half arsed scheme you had is now cancelled.”

“We're coming in with you” said Steven.

Scott smiled “I know you. Ex bootneck?” He used the term Royal Marines used for themselves. Steven nodded. “Twelve years in the Paras myself” said Scott.

Steven nodded. There was intense rivalry between the Royal Marines and the Parachute Regiment, both amongst the best soldiers in the world, but Steven felt they were in safe hands.

“Tell me everything and then we'll decide,” Scott said, “but I'll tell you this, any hero crashes in ahead of me and I'll shoot him in the arse and claim it was an accident”

As the three of them talked Finn arrived back.

“The fire escape door has been wedged slightly open so I used my house key to lever it open it all the way”

“OK, we have one female armed assailant and one unarmed male on the fourth floor and potentially we have a hostage situation” Sergeant Scott spoke clearly to his two colleagues.

“And you three will remain out of the way” he looked directly at Steven and an unspoken message was exchanged.

“One floor down” said Steven quietly. Scott gave the smallest of nods, he knew he couldn't keep them out without more officers.

“Let's go”

The three armed officers all had Glock handguns strapped to their thighs and each carried a Heckler & Koch MP5SF submachine gun. In line with regulations they were set to single fire mode.

The three officers moved silently up the stairs, checking each landing despite the bright lights. At the top floor Tony Scott nodded to one of his team who produced a flat bladed knife and slid it silently into the gap between the door frame and the door. He levered the door quietly and it moved slowly open. They could hear voices inside. Two voices.

As a well oiled machine they entered the apartment, checking bedrooms each side of the corridor. Hand signals indicated a clear room and they moved on.

In the lead Tony Scott was well experienced at being first in through the door. He'd done it in Iraq and Afghanistan and he was as cool as a cucumber. As they approached the sitting room the voices got louder, but then...

“I AM NOT STUPID” Holly screamed.

The three officers entered the room.

“ARMED POLICE, ARMED POLICE. DROP YOUR WEAPON”

All three officers were shouting. The room was suddenly a bewildering cauldron of shouting and confusion.

Adam threw himself to the floor protected by the sofa and the heavy oak coffee table.

Holly turned, partly in response to the source of the shouting. As she turned she instinctively moved her hand and, as the gun turned to face Tony Scott, he pulled the trigger twice.

Standard practice, he had aimed for central body mass. The first round had hit dead centre and turned Holly's body slightly with the

momentum. The second round hit her heart and Holly died instantly.

The police use hollow-point 9mm ammunition to avoid rounds passing through and injuring bystanders. It means the bullet expands on impact causing huge damage to the body.

Holly dropped the gun as she fell. A crumpled, lifeless mass.

From nowhere Finn leapt on Adam "Oh my God, tell me you're OK?"

"I'm fine, no injuries except my pride. Can't believe I was so stupid"

Steven crossed to Holly's body but it was clear she was dead.

One of the other officers picked up her gun. "Dead before she hit the ground I should think"

Steven nodded, he was well used to that sort of cool objectivity.

Adam looked at Holly's body. He was surprised at how little blood was leaking out. From TV he would have expected a growing pool of blood but... there was almost nothing.

Marc watched as Sergeant Scott's weapons were bagged by his colleagues. There would be an investigation but he felt sure the bodycam footage would confirm the immediate threat to life.

He shook Scott's hand. "Thank you" he said simply. He crossed to Steven and touched him on the shoulder.

"Are you OK?" he asked.

"Well, I'll probably get a bollocking because I'm supposed to be on call but apart from that... I'm fine"

"I'll wait here until the cavalry arrive but you go off. You'll need to give a statement tomorrow. I'll take the boys home as soon as I can."

"Call your new friend Margaret. Get yourself some heavyweight backup." Steven grinned.

Adam stood up slowly. "Can we go home?" he asked Finn. "I think I've got a car waiting outside"

Nobody would know if Holly would have successfully staked a claim to Adam's fortune.

Nobody would ever know what her real goal was, except Holly, and she wasn't telling anyone.

Chapter Twenty One - Epilogue

Although totally unaware of his own part in the drama, Neil Bevan had read news reports of the police shooting an armed burglar three weeks earlier. He'd accepted that Olena had never existed and somehow had twisted reality to believe that he would have rumbled the scam himself before it went any further. He was comfortable with that altered narrative.

It was 11am when Alison Streeter, an admin supervisor from across the corridor, brought him a coffee at his desk. She had been doing this for the past few weeks and even included a small oat biscuit on the saucer. They had always exchanged pleasantries: the weather, colleagues' antics or last night's TV.

After eighteen years of marriage Allison's husband had announced he was leaving to go and live in Thailand. He is now her ex-husband. She didn't mind, they had no children and, truth be told, she found him tedious.

"Neil?" Alison asked "would you like to go out for a coffee or a drink after work?"

Neil looked up and smiled "Alison, you took the words right out of my mouth. That would be lovely"

A few days earlier Sergeant Tony Scott, who had been manning a desk for a while, was cleared in the shooting of Holly Foreman. Bodycam footage from Scott and his two colleagues clearly showed Holly's gun pointing directly at him with her finger dangerously on the trigger. Appropriate warnings had been clear and sufficient.

It had been a month now since the incident at Adam's apartment and Adam had had the whole place cleaned and repainted. Moving out felt like a surrender and Adam was determined not to surrender. He resolved to move back in as soon as possible.

He'd talked long into the night with Finn. It helped that Finn didn't sleep much. Adam felt a feeling of guilt, that he and his family hadn't helped Holly. As ridiculous as it sounded he felt they should have helped, even though they knew nothing of Holly's existence. Adam even briefly entertained the notion that his father would have refrained from drinking if he'd have known but he knew that was highly improbable.

Finn asked how many times his father had been dried out, which resolved that issue for Adam.

Adam also felt some guilt at his relief that it was all over. Again Finn came to the rescue with common sense and logic.

He felt unresolved anger over Holly's action. He confessed he wanted to attack her, to somehow overpower her and subdue her.

This time his own logic came into play. Trying to attack an armed opponent when you are unarmed is the stuff of action movies, not real life.

All in all Adam felt he had come through the ordeal with most of his sanity intact. Finn had helped. Finn was like a rock to cling to and, for Finn, Adam was the same.

They had become so close. They were best friends *and* lovers. They laughed together and, on rare occasions, held each other during rough times.

Today had been a good day. Finn had taken Adam to meet his Mum and stepmum. They took the tube to Hampstead. It was one of the most expensive areas of London. The sort of area where the local artisanal coffee shop is jam-packed with people you would know from the TV and you'd often see a Hollywood A-lister in the posh supermarket.

Finn's Mum was Ella and she lived in a modest, for Hampstead, four bedroom town house. She was slim and stunningly attractive. Finn had told Adam she used to be a model but now ran Yoga classes.

Ella enveloped Adam in a hug that might have caused spinal damage.

“See...” Finn laughed “a whole family of huggers. There's no escape”

“You gorgeous boy,” Ella exclaimed. “I’m so sorry for what you have had to endure.”

“Well, it's over now. She's gone” Adam felt a little embarrassed.

“What do you mean?” Ella said with a sly smile “I was talking about Finn”

They were laughing as Rose came into the room - Finn's stepmum.

“If she teases you too much I can always lock her in the garden shed,” she told Adam as she also hugged him.

“Would a vegan lunch be OK for you Adam?” Rose asked.

“Yes of course. Anything, thank you” Adam replied.

“OK but the rest of us are having beef” Rose roared with laughter as she walked back to the kitchen.

“Can you all stop picking on my boyfriend or we're going out for fast-food”

“Wash your mouth out” shouted Rose from the other room.

It had been a wonderful lunch with lots of laughter and the obligatory embarrassing anecdotes about Finn.

Finn's sister Alicia, but known as Ali, had arrived mid-meal and had joined them for dessert. It turned out she'd been on a park run and had stopped for a catch up with friends. Adam looked at the happy relationships around the table.

“This is like heaven” thought Adam.

Later in bed, full of dinner and good times. They were totally sated in every way. Lying side by sides, holding hands and a little breathless.

Adam had been pondering a question.

“Finn? ” he asked, “a while ago you were talking about genetic alcoholism and said you will need to keep an eye on me for the rest of your life.”

“I did say that and I meant it” Finn replied. “Would that be OK with you?”

“More than OK. I'd like us to be together forever”

“The only thing is we'd need a pre-nuptial agreement” said Finn. There was a smile in his voice and Adam was used to the cheeky ribbing from the entire family.

“You know I don't care about...” Adam started but Finn interrupted.

“Not for you... for me!” Finn was laughing at Adam's confused face.

“My little partnership has just finished our accounts for our first financial year. We had agreed to put 20% aside for running costs and expenses and divide up the rest”

“OK...” said Adam slowly drawing out the word.

“With billings of a touch oversix million pounds, my end is over a million. I'm rich! Not you rich, but certainly doing pretty well.”

“Wow, you can take me shopping tomorrow and buy me some trinkets.”

Adam and Finn looked at each other. They felt happy and confident. The future looked good.